

EVLVED

VOL. 03



A FIELD MANUAL

The Travel *System.*

Thirty destinations across four continents. The hotels I'd book, the places I'd skip, the system I actually use. Not theory. The real thing.

BY KEIT

EVOLVE BEYOND.

THE TRAVEL SYSTEM

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FROM THE AUTHOR

Why this *exists*.

TWENTY-TWO-PLUS COUNTRIES. ONE BOOK. EVERYTHING I WISH SOMEONE HAD TOLD ME.

I am from Estonia. I now live in Bali. The way I got from one to the other was completely by accident.

In early 2020, just as COVID was starting, I was at the airport flying to Vietnam. At check-in they told me I needed a visa, and the visa cost more than a one-way flight to somewhere else. I looked at the departure board, saw Bali, and bought the ticket on the spot. That was my first time in Indonesia. I have lived here ever since.

Bali was already a dream destination. I just did not expect to arrive by accident. That story has stuck with me because it sums up almost everything I have learned about travel since: *the best trips are usually one decision away from the wrong ones*. The only thing that separates them is whether you have the information to make the call confidently when the moment comes.

Since then I have travelled to twenty-two-plus countries. I have stayed in everything from \$15 dorm beds to \$1,000 suites. I have flown business class on long-haul and budget airlines around Asia. I have lost luggage, missed flights, paid the wrong taxi fare, eaten the wrong street food, walked into the wrong neighbourhoods. I have also had some of the best experiences of my life in places that almost did not happen because I nearly trusted the wrong blog post.

People have always asked what I actually do, where I actually go, how I actually book. The cat is out of the bag now. This is the system.

I built this book from *my own mistakes*, and from the questions my audience has asked me over the years. Both matter. The mistakes show you where things go wrong. The questions show me what people actually need to know. The intersection of those two is what made it into these pages.

I do not want you to make the same mistakes I did. There is no glory in figuring everything out the hard way. This is a guide for the people who want to travel well, save money on the things that do not matter, and spend it on the things that do.

THE FOUR THINGS I WISH SOMEONE HAD TOLD ME EARLY

LESSON 01

Business class is *not always worth it*

I used to book business class for the experience, regardless of flight length. It is not worth it on short and medium-haul. On a 4-hour flight, you arrive fine in economy. On a 14-hour flight, business is the difference between landing functional and landing destroyed. Pay for it when it matters. Skip it when it does not. There is a full breakdown of when in the Flights section at the back.

LESSON 02

Arrive at the airport *early*

Three hours for international. Ninety minutes for domestic. Rushing through security and to the gate is the worst way to start a trip, and the savings of arriving an hour later are zero. Get there early. Sit down. Eat something. Walk to the gate calmly. The trip starts the moment you stop rushing.

LESSON 03

Download movies *before* you fly

Not every plane has working entertainment. Half the budget airlines have none. Download Netflix shows or movies offline before you leave home. A 12-hour flight with no entertainment and a flat phone is its own kind of suffering.

LESSON 04

Always ask for the *extra legroom seat* at check-in

Nine times out of ten they give it to you for free, especially if you ask politely and the flight is not full. Most travellers do not know to ask. The exit row, the bulkhead, the seat behind business class are all usually free upgrades if you ask the right way at the right moment. Smile, ask, accept whatever they offer.

WHY THIS BOOK

There is no point hoarding what I have learned. The fastest way to travel well is to copy someone who already does. This book is the shortcut.

Keit

Bali, 2026

READ THIS FIRST

How to *use* this book.

THREE WAYS IN. PICK THE ONE THAT FITS YOUR TRIP.

The Travel System is not a country guide. It is a destination guide for thirty places I have either been to or stayed in long enough to recommend. The format is the same for each. The opinions are mine. The hotels are real. The links work.

You do not need to read this front to back. Most people will use it in one of three ways.

WAY 01 · YOU KNOW WHERE YOU ARE GOING

Jump to the *destination*.

Find the city or island in the table of contents, open it, read the lead paragraph and the "Where to stay" section. Pick the tier that fits your budget. Use the booking link. The "My Take" and Do/Skip boxes are there to give you the editorial view in 60 seconds.

WAY 02 · YOU KNOW ROUGHLY WHERE YOU WANT TO GO

Use the *multi-stop routes*.

At the back of the book, after the destination chapters, there are pre-built itineraries that combine 2-4 destinations into a single trip. Southeast Asia loops, Mediterranean island-hopping, Northern Europe by train, Asia capitals in 10 days, and so on. Use these as a starting point and adjust to your dates.

WAY 03 · YOU ARE NOT SURE WHERE TO GO YET

Browse by *region*.

The destinations are organised by region in the contents. Skim the lead paragraphs of each. The first three sentences of every destination tell you what kind of trip it is and who it is for. If a place is not for you, you will know in 30 seconds.

HOW TO READ EACH DESTINATION

Every destination follows the same structure. Once you have read one, you can read any other in about three minutes.

SECTION 01

Lead and context paragraphs

What the destination is, who it is for, and how to choose your neighbourhood within it. If you only read two paragraphs, read these.

SECTION 02

Where to stay

Hotels at every budget tier. Iconic (\$600+/night), Premium (\$300-600), Mid (\$150-300), Smart Value (\$60-150), Backpacker (\$20-60). Each card includes the area, a one-paragraph review, a price-from estimate, and a direct booking link.

SECTION 03

Quick facts

Best and worst months, the airport, how to get around, recommended stay length. The practical answers in one box.

SECTION 04

Do / Skip

Five things worth doing. Four things to skip. Both lists are short on purpose. Most travel guides recommend everything, which is the same as recommending nothing.

SECTION 05

My Take

The honest editorial summary. The one paragraph I would say to a friend asking me about the place over dinner. If you trust nothing else in the destination, trust this part.

THE PRICE TIERS, EXPLAINED

Hotel prices in this book are deliberately tiered the same way across every destination. The dollar ranges are real, based on average shoulder-season pricing. Peak season adds 30-60%. Last-minute booking adds another 30-50%.

ICONIC

From \$600 / night

The defining hotel of the destination. Most destinations have one. Some have none. Where these exist, they are unforgettable. Where they do not, the Premium tier is the ceiling.

PREMIUM

\$300-600 / night

High-end international standard. Five-star service. Usually one or two per destination.

MID

\$150-300 / night

Design boutiques, smaller luxury, four-star. The sweet spot for most travellers staying 1-3 nights. Present at almost every destination.

SMART VALUE

\$60-150 / night

The best fair-priced option in the destination. Where I go for longer stays of 3+ nights, or where the budget version still feels good. Present at every destination.

BACKPACKER

\$20-60 / night

Dorm beds, design hostels, the cheap private rooms. Two options per destination where a real budget scene exists. Travel does not have to be expensive.

THE LOGISTICS SECTION

At the back of the book is the logistics chapter. Flights, packing, money, travel-day routine, SIM and eSIM, travel insurance, scam awareness, and the apps you need on your phone. Read this once before your first trip with the book. Refer back to it on the morning of every flight. It is the boring part of travel done so you can stop thinking about it.

ONE LAST THING

This book is opinionated on purpose. Travel writing is mostly bad because it tries to please everyone. If you disagree with something here, good. Make the call. Take the trip. Make your own mistakes. Just make sure they are different from mine.

BALI · INDONESIA

Canggu

THE WEST COAST. SURF, BRUNCH, BEACH CLUBS, MOTORBIKES, SUNSETS.

If you have only seen Bali on Instagram, you have already seen Canggu. Cafe culture, surf breaks, beach clubs, rice paddies that survived the boom. It is busier than it used to be and the traffic is real, but the energy is the reason people keep coming back.

Canggu sits on the southwest coast, north of Seminyak, anchored by two beaches: Batu Bolong (the busy one, surf and beach clubs) and Echo Beach (quieter, more local). The neighborhoods that matter are Berawa (upscale, beach clubs, gyms), Batu Bolong (the heart, walkable to everything), and Pererenan (the new quieter zone people are moving to). Pick the area first, then pick the hotel.

WHERE TO STAY

PREMIUM

COMO Uma *Canggu*

Echo Beach · Batu Bolong area

Beachfront 5-star with surf-themed design and the COMO Shambhala spa. Quieter end of Canggu but walkable to the action. Beach club access and a strong wellness program.

From ~\$400 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=COMO+Uma+Canggu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=COMO+Uma+Canggu)

MID · BOUTIQUE

The Slow *Canggu*

Batu Bolong · 500m from beach

Tropical brutalist design hotel that started the Canggu boutique scene. Some rooms have plunge pools. In the middle of the action. Built for people who want to be where things are happening.

From ~\$300 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Slow+Canggu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Slow+Canggu)

MID

Hotel *Tugu* Bali

Echo Beach · beachfront

Romantic museum-hotel filled with Indonesian and Javanese antiques. Each suite is its own world. Beach access. Best choice if you want Bali culture with the comfort of a five-star.

From ~\$280 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Tugu+Bali+Canggu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Tugu+Bali+Canggu)

SMART VALUE

ZIN *Canggu* Resort & Villas

Nelayan Beach · gym district

More than a hotel. A small empire with its own cycling studio, cafe, spa and shop. Practical, well-located, and great if fitness is part of your trip.

From ~\$130 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=ZIN+Canggu+Resort+Villas](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=ZIN+Canggu+Resort+Villas)

BACKPACKER

Tribal *Bali**Pererenan · coworking, pool*

Best digital-nomad hostel in Bali. Custom-built rooms, an enormous coworking space, an infinity pool, on-site cafe and bar. If you are remote-working from Bali, this is the soft landing.

From ~\$50 / night (dorm), ~\$110 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Tribal+Bali+Pererenan

BACKPACKER

The Farm *Hostel**Canggu · central, walking distance to beach*

The original chilled-out Canggu hostel. Big pool, included breakfast, social without being a party hostel. Has been a backpacker landmark since 2015 and still earns it.

From ~\$15 / night (dorm), ~\$60 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Farm+Hostel+Canggu

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to September.</i> July and September are the sweet spot.
WORST MONTHS	January and February (heaviest rain), late December (peak prices, crowds).
AIRPORT	Ngurah Rai International (DPS). 60 to 90 min by car depending on traffic.
GET AROUND	Scooter is fastest. Gojek/Grab for cars. Traffic is brutal at sunset.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. Most stay 7 to 10.

DO

- + Surf at Batu Bolong (beginners) or Echo Beach (intermediate+)
- + Sunset at La Brisa or The Lawn
- + Brunch at Crate, Milk & Madu, or Kynd Community
- + Train at Body Factory or do a class at Zycle
- + Day trip to Tanah Lot temple at sunset

SKIP

- Driving anywhere between 5 to 7pm
- Eating at Finns Beach Club for the food (go for the vibe only)
- Booking a hotel without checking which neighborhood
- December last two weeks unless you love crowds

MY TAKE

*If you are visiting Bali for the first time, do not start in Canggu. Start in Uluwatu or Ubud, then come to Canggu for the back end of the trip when you want to **be around people** again.*

BALI · INDONESIA

Uluwatu

THE CLIFFS. WHITE SAND, SURF TEMPLES, SUNSET, SLOW DAYS.

If Canggu is the energy, Uluwatu is the answer. Limestone cliffs, hidden beaches, quieter roads, and some of the best hotels in Asia perched directly above the Indian Ocean. This is where Bali still feels like Bali.

Uluwatu covers the Bukit Peninsula, the southern tip of the island. It is split into a few zones: Padang Padang (the main beach hub, walkable, lively), Bingin (boutique, surf-focused), Balangan (quieter beaches, family-friendly), and the south coast around Melasti and Ungasan (the most remote, where the biggest resorts live). The driving distances are real. Pick your zone before your hotel.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Bulgari Resort *Bali*

Pecatu · 150m clifftop

Italian luxury house meets Balinese cliff. 64 villas, all private pools, private inclinator down to a private beach club. The hotel that defines what Uluwatu can be at the top end.

From ~\$650 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Bulgari+Resort+Bali+Uluwatu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Bulgari+Resort+Bali+Uluwatu)

PREMIUM

Six Senses *Uluwatu*

Pecatu · clifftop, ocean-facing

Sustainable design, dramatic views, and a wellness program that justifies the trip alone. Quieter than Bulgari, more eco-luxe in feel.

From ~\$550 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Six+Senses+Uluwatu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Six+Senses+Uluwatu)

PREMIUM · RESORT

Alila Villas *Uluwatu**Ungasan · clifftop*

All-villa, all-private-pool. 50-meter cliff-edge pool with the most photographed view in Bali. Quieter Ungasan location means you commute for nightlife but your stay is a sanctuary.

From ~\$700 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Alila+Villas+Uluwatu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Alila+Villas+Uluwatu)

MID · BOUTIQUE

Suarga *Padang Padang**Padang Padang · steps from beach*

Eco-luxe boutique close to the action without the resort price. Open-air design, beach access, walkable to bars and food. Solid mid-tier with character.

From ~\$200 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Suarga+Padang+Padang](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Suarga+Padang+Padang)

SMART VALUE

Radisson Blu Bali *Uluwatu**Pecatu · clifftop, near Padang Padang*

Reliable five-star at a fraction of Bulgari money. Big pool, multiple restaurants, walkable area. Best non-luxury choice on the cliffs.

From ~\$180 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Radisson+Blu+Bali+Uluwatu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Radisson+Blu+Bali+Uluwatu)

BACKPACKER

Karma *Backpacker* House*Ungasan · daily beach shuttle*

Friendly, inclusive surf hostel with a real community feel. Free dinners and BBQ nights, daily shuttle to the beach, quiet hours after 11pm. Best chill backpacker in the Bukit.

From ~\$15 / night (dorm), ~\$45 (private)

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Karma+Backpacker+House+Uluwatu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Karma+Backpacker+House+Uluwatu)

BACKPACKER

Kubu *Container**Padang Padang · 500m from Padang Padang Beach*

Shipping-container budget stay between Padang Padang and Impossibles beach. Tiny private rooms, a pool, walking distance to two of the best surf breaks on the Bukit. Cheapest way to wake up next to the waves.

From ~\$40 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kubu+Container+Uluwatu](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kubu+Container+Uluwatu)

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to October.</i> Dry season, world-class surf, cliffs at their photogenic best.
WORST MONTHS	January and February (rain, slippery cliff paths).
AIRPORT	Ngurah Rai International (DPS). 30 to 60 min by car.
GET AROUND	Scooter required for freedom. Distances are deceptive on the Bukit.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 5 nights ideal.

DO

- + Sunset at Single Fin or Karma Beach Club
- + Watch the kecak fire dance at Uluwatu Temple at sunset (the original, not staged)
- + Surf Padang Padang or watch the pros if you cannot
- + Hidden beach mission to Nyang Nyang or Suluban
- + Dinner at Mana, Sundara, or Il Ristorante (Bulgari)

SKIP

- Trying to do it as a day trip from Canggu (you will hate the drive)
- Renting a car instead of a scooter (parking is hell)
- Wet season cliff paths if you have any sense
- Staying in Ungasan if you want walkable nightlife

MY TAKE

*If you only have **five days in Bali**, spend three of them in Uluwatu. The cliffs are not optional. They are the reason you came.*

BALI · INDONESIA

Ubud

THE JUNGLE. RICE TERRACES, TEMPLES, YOGA, SLOW MORNINGS.

Ubud is the cultural and spiritual heart of Bali. Rice paddies, jungle, art markets, yoga, and some of the most photographed hotels on earth. It is not a beach trip. It is a different speed entirely.

Ubud splits cleanly into two zones. Central Ubud (around Monkey Forest Road and Jalan Bisma) is walkable, energetic, full of cafes, yoga studios, and shops. The outer villages (Sayan, Payangan, Tegallalang, Kedewatan, Kenderan) are quieter, deeper in the jungle, and home to the legendary luxury resorts. Central Ubud if you want to walk everywhere. Outer villages if you want to disappear.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Mandapa, A Ritz-Carlton *Reserve*

Kedewatan · Ayung River

Designed as a Balinese village along the Ayung River with its own rice paddies and temple. The benchmark Ubud luxury resort. Suites and villas, private pools, multiple dining venues, private guide service.

From ~\$1,200 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Mandapa+Ritz+Carlton+Reserve+Ubud](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Mandapa+Ritz+Carlton+Reserve+Ubud)

ICONIC

Four Seasons Resort Bali at *Sayan*

Sayan · jungle valley

The hotel built like a flying saucer over the rice paddies. Iconic infinity pool views into the valley. Genuinely one of the great hotels in Asia.

From ~\$900 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Sayan+Ubud](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Sayan+Ubud)

PREMIUM

Kenran Resort *Ubud**Kenderan · rice paddies, Petanu River*

Pool villas tucked into the jungle above the Petanu River, fifteen minutes from central Ubud. The infinity pool over the river valley is the photo. Quiet, secluded, you commute for dinner but you sleep deep. A personal favourite of mine.

From ~\$300 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kenran+Resort+Ubud

PREMIUM

COMO Uma *Ubud**Sanggingan · 5 min north of center*

More accessible than the legends but still genuinely luxe. COMO Shambhala wellness program, jungle setting, walkable to a great food street.

From ~\$400 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=COMO+Uma+Ubud

MID · BOUTIQUE

Bisma *Eight**Jalan Bisma · central, jungle-edge*

Contemporary boutique with Japanese soaking tubs, infinity pool with jungle views, walkable to all of central Ubud, and free yoga classes. The smartest mid-tier in Ubud.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Bisma+Eight+Ubud

SMART VALUE

Maya *Ubud* Resort & Spa*Peliatan · Petanu River gorge*

Sprawling jungle resort with the famous riverside infinity pool. Bigger and more "resort" than boutique. Best for honeymoons and wellness stays at a fair price.

From ~\$180 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Maya+Ubud+Resort+Spa

BACKPACKER

Puri Garden *Hotel & Hostel**Central Ubud · 10 min walk to Monkey Forest*

The famous Ubud hostel with a cinema room, two pools, dog therapy, daily yoga and free breakfast. Far more design than the usual hostel. Walking distance to Monkey Forest Road. The best social budget option in Ubud.

From ~\$25 / night (dorm), ~\$90 (private)

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Puri+Garden+Hotel+Hostel+Ubud](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Puri+Garden+Hotel+Hostel+Ubud)

BACKPACKER

Pillow Inn *Ubud**Central Ubud · walking distance to everything*

Small, clean budget guesthouse-hostel in the centre. Quieter than Puri Garden, friendlier price. The right pick if you want a private room in the middle of Ubud at hostel money.

From ~\$30 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pillow+Inn+Ubud](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pillow+Inn+Ubud)

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>April to October.</i> Drier, cooler nights, jungle still green.
WORST MONTHS	January and February (heavy rain, jungle paths slippery, gloomier light).
AIRPORT	Ngurah Rai (DPS). 90 to 120 min by car.
GET AROUND	Scooter for distances, walking for central Ubud.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 nights ideal.

DO

- + Campuhan Ridge walk at sunrise (do this before the heat)
- + Tegalalang rice terraces (early morning before the buses)
- + Sacred Monkey Forest (genuinely worth it, watch your phone)
- + Yoga at The Yoga Barn or Radiantly Alive
- + Eat at Locavore, Mozaic, or Hujan Locale

SKIP

- The Bali Swing (overpriced tourist trap, plenty of free swings nearby)
- Booking a hotel without checking how far it is from central Ubud
- Staying more than 5 nights unless you are doing a long retreat
- Driving yourself if you have not driven in Asia before

MY TAKE

*Ubud at the right hotel is one of the great resort experiences anywhere in the world. Ubud at the wrong hotel is a hot, sticky, traffic-clogged mistake. **The hotel choice matters more here than anywhere else in Bali.***

LOMBOK · INDONESIA

Gili *Islands*

THE THREE ISLANDS. NO CARS, NO SCOOTERS, WHITE SAND, TURTLES, SNORKELING, SLOW.

Three small islands off the northwest coast of Lombok. No motorised vehicles allowed on any of them. You get around by bicycle, horse cart, or your feet. It is the closest you can get to a desert island without leaving the booking platform.

Pick the island first. Gili Trawangan (Gili T) is the biggest and busiest, with the bars, the dive shops, the late nights and most of the hotels. Gili Air is the middle child, the smartest pick for most people: enough food and bars to keep you fed, quiet enough to actually relax, the best beaches of the three. Gili Meno is the smallest and the quietest, basically a honeymoon island. The boat between them takes ten to fifteen minutes. You can hop.

WHERE TO STAY

PREMIUM

Pondok *Santi* Estate

Gili Trawangan · south coast, beachfront

Eco-luxe villas on a former coconut plantation on the quiet side of Gili T. Thatched ceilings, timber, beachfront BBQ dining, the resort's own wooden outrigger for day sails. The best balance of luxury and island authenticity on the Gilis.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pondok+Santi+Estate+Gili+Trawangan

MID · BOUTIQUE

Cocana *Resort**Gili Trawangan · west coast, sunset side*

Gili T's first proper luxury resort. Lagoon suites, private pool villas, a strong spa, and the Sunset Club for happy hour. Polished but still feels island. Tucked away from the party streets so you can sleep.

From ~\$250 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Cocana+Resort+Gili+Trawangan](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Cocana+Resort+Gili+Trawangan)

MID · BOUTIQUE

Kuno *Villas**Gili Trawangan · north end, quieter*

Antique Javanese teak houses restored as private-pool villas. Daily yoga, breakfast served in the villa, deeply atmospheric. The kind of place you do not want to leave. Adults-oriented, not for kids.

From ~\$210 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kuno+Villas+Gili+Trawangan](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kuno+Villas+Gili+Trawangan)

SMART VALUE

PinkCoco *Gili Air**Gili Air · beachfront, adults-only*

Adults-only design hotel on Gili Air with direct beach access and a personality that does not take itself too seriously. Stylish without trying too hard. Best Gili Air mid-tier pick.

From ~\$110 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=PinkCoco+Gili+Air](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=PinkCoco+Gili+Air)

BACKPACKER

Pelangi *Cottages* Gili Air*Gili Air · north coast, near beach*

Traditional Lombok-style bungalows under palms, a small pool, simple breakfast, beach a few steps away. Clean, honest, friendly. The kind of place that makes Gili Air feel like Gili Air.

From ~\$45 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pelangi+Cottages+Gili+Air](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pelangi+Cottages+Gili+Air)

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to September.</i> Dry season, calm seas, the snorkeling is unreal.
WORST MONTHS	January and February (rain, rougher crossings, some operators stop running).
AIRPORT	Lombok International (LOP), 1.5h by car plus 15 min by fast boat. Or fly to Bali (DPS) and take a 2h fast boat from Padang Bai or Serangan.
GET AROUND	Bicycle or walk. No cars, no scooters on any of the three islands.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 nights is the sweet spot.

DO

- + Snorkel the turtle spots off Gili Air or Gili Meno (you will see them)
- + Sunset at the swings on Gili T's west coast
- + Day hop between all three islands by public boat
- + Dive course at one of the long-established Gili schools if you have the time
- + Eat at Pachamama or Mowie's on Gili Air for a real meal

SKIP

- Gili T if you want quiet. You will be miserable.
- The cheap fast boats from Bali in monsoon season
- Mushroom shakes (yes they are everywhere, no it is not a good idea)
- Booking a beachfront room on the side of Gili T that gets the parties

MY TAKE

*If it is your first time, stay on **Gili Air**. It is the right balance of quiet and alive. Skip Gili T unless you specifically want the nightlife, and only go to Meno if you are on a honeymoon or actively trying to disappear.*

THAILAND

Bangkok

THE CITY. STREET FOOD, SKYTRAINS, ROOFTOPS, TEMPLES, TRAFFIC, ENERGY.

Bangkok is the most rewarding chaotic city in Asia. Twenty-million people, a hundred neighborhoods, the best street food in the world, rooftops that will ruin you for other rooftops, and a temple around every corner. It does not give itself up quickly. You have to put hours in.

Pick your base by what you are here for. Sukhumvit (around the BTS Skytrain from Asok to Phrom Phong) is the convenience play: malls, restaurants, gyms, easy transit, modern hotels. Riverside (Chao Phraya) is where the legendary hotels live: Mandarin Oriental, Capella, Peninsula, Four Seasons. It is slower, quieter, more atmospheric, but you commute everywhere by river boat or BTS. Silom/Sathorn is the business district, well connected to both. Old Town (around Khao San) is backpacker territory and useful for one or two nights of temple-heavy sightseeing, not for a whole trip.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Mandarin *Oriental* Bangkok

Riverside · Bang Rak, Chao Phraya

The most storied hotel in Asia. Open since 1879, still the gold standard. The Authors' Lounge for afternoon tea is a Bangkok experience with no equivalent. Book the River Wing, not the Garden Wing, if you do this. Riverboat shuttle to the BTS line.

From ~\$650 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Mandarin+Oriental+Bangkok

PREMIUM

Capella *Bangkok*

Riverside · Charoen Krung

All-suite, every room with a private balcony directly over the river. Opened 2020, immediately Forbes Five-Star. Côte by Mauro Colagreco for dinner. The most lavish new hotel in Southeast Asia, full stop.

From ~\$550 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Capella+Bangkok

MID

Rosewood *Bangkok**Phloen Chit · central, BTS-connected*

Five-star with the best location in the city. Three minutes to BTS Phloen Chit, connected to Central Embassy mall, walkable to half of Sukhumvit. The luxury choice when you do not want to commute from the river.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Rosewood+Bangkok

SMART VALUE

Grand Centre Point *Sukhumvit**Sukhumvit · multiple locations near BTS*

Spacious serviced-apartment rooms with kitchenettes, big pools, gyms, walking distance to BTS stations on every property. The smartest mid-tier in Bangkok for repeat visitors. Locations at Terminal 21, Ploenchit, and Pattanakarn all work.

From ~\$130 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Grand+Centre+Point+Sukhumvit+Bangkok

BACKPACKER

Lub d *Siam**Siam Square · steps from BTS National Stadium*

Design-forward hostel chain with private rooms and dorms, social common areas, and an unbeatable Siam location for first-time shopping and sightseeing. Clean, modern, and not a party hostel.

From ~\$25 / night (dorm), ~\$60 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Lub+d+Bangkok+Siam

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>November to February.</i> Cool season, dry, the only time the heat is manageable.
WORST MONTHS	April (hottest, plus Songkran water-festival chaos), September and October (heaviest rain).
AIRPORT	Suvarnabhumi (BKK) is main, 30 to 60 min to central. Don Mueang (DMK) handles low-cost carriers.
GET AROUND	BTS Skytrain and MRT for anything along the lines. Grab for everything else. Tuk-tuks are a tourist tax, not transport.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 nights to actually see it.

D O

- + Grand Palace and Wat Pho early morning (before 10am, before the heat)
- + Chatuchak weekend market, then a foot massage afterwards
- + Eat your way through Thonglor (Sukhumvit Soi 55) for a night
- + Sky bar at Lebua, Vertigo at Banyan Tree, or Penthouse at Park Hyatt for sunset
- + Muay thai at Rajadamnern or Lumpinee stadium if you are into it

S K I P

- Tuk-tuk "tours" that always end at a gem shop or a tailor
- Khao San Road past 9pm unless you are nineteen
- Visiting in mid-April unless you actively want to get water-cannoned for three days
- Booking a hotel that is not within ten minutes of a BTS station

M Y T A K E

*Bangkok rewards the second visit more than the first. The first trip you will run around chasing temples and palaces and feel exhausted. The second trip you will stay in one neighborhood, eat your way through it, and finally **understand the city**.*

THAILAND

Phuket

THE BIG ISLAND. BEACH RESORTS, ANDAMAN SEA, DAY-TRIP ISLANDS, EVERY BUDGET.

Phuket is bigger than people think. It is a full island, not a beach. Different coasts, different vibes, different prices, and your trip will be defined by where you base. The west coast holds all the beaches. The east coast holds the marina and the day-trip boats. The town in the middle holds the culture.

The west coast splits cleanly. Patong is the chaos: nightlife, mass tourism, neon, the cheap end. Karon and Kata to the south are calmer and family-friendly. Kamala and Surin to the north are where the better hotels cluster, the beaches are cleaner, and the price-to-quality ratio is the best on the island. Bang Tao and Laguna further north are luxury resort territory. Phuket Old Town is colonial architecture, cafes, and street art, and it is worth at least a day even if you are not staying there. Pick your coast before your hotel.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Rosewood *Phuket*

Emerald Bay · 60 min from airport, secluded

Seventy-one pavilions and villas in Emerald Bay, with a 600-metre private beachfront. Four restaurants, the Asaya wellness concept, contemporary Thai architecture into the hillside. The benchmark luxury resort on Phuket.

From ~\$800 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Rosewood+Phuket](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Rosewood+Phuket)

PREMIUM

Keemala *Phuket*

Kamala · rainforest, hillside

Tropical wonderland in the Kamala rainforest. Bird's nest villas, clay pool cottages, the architecture genuinely unlike anything else in Thailand. Wellness-focused, deeply photogenic. Fifteen minutes to Patong if you want it, far enough to forget about it if you do not.

From ~\$500 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Keemala+Phuket](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Keemala+Phuket)

MID

The *Surin* Phuket*Pansea Beach · between Surin and Bang Tao*

Cottage-style resort on a semi-private beach shared with Amanpuri next door. No elevators, open-air walkways, no flash. Quietly one of the best hotels on the island, and a fraction of the price of its neighbours.

From ~\$280 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Surin+Phuket](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Surin+Phuket)

SMART VALUE

Twinpalms *Phuket**Surin · 175m from beach*

Stylish, modern, lagoon-pool design hotel with private terraces and a clean Scandinavian-meets-tropical look. Popular with couples who want quiet luxury without paying iconic-tier prices. The smartest value play in Surin.

From ~\$160 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Twinpalms+Phuket+Surin](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Twinpalms+Phuket+Surin)

BACKPACKER

Lub d Phuket *Patong**Patong · 5 min walk to beach*

The reliable design hostel chain again, this time with mixed dorms, private rooms, a pool, and a social common area. Walking distance to the Patong nightlife if you want it, far enough from Bangla Road to actually sleep.

From ~\$20 / night (dorm), ~\$55 (private)

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Lub+d+Phuket+Patong](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Lub+d+Phuket+Patong)

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>November to April.</i> Dry season, calm Andaman Sea, the day-trip boats actually run.
WORST MONTHS	June to October. Monsoon season, rough seas, many beaches have red flags, some boat trips cancelled.
AIRPORT	Phuket International (HKT). 30 to 60 min to the west coast beaches depending on traffic.
GET AROUND	Scooter if you are confident. Grab works in most areas. Taxis are overpriced and a negotiation. The island is bigger than you think.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. 7 nights is ideal if you are doing day trips.

D O

- + Phi Phi Islands day trip from a smaller speedboat operator (skip the big tour boats)
- + James Bond Island and Phang Nga Bay by long-tail boat
- + Phuket Old Town for a half day of Sino-Portuguese architecture and cafes
- + Sunset at Promthep Cape, the southern tip of the island
- + Eat at Mom Tri's Kitchen at the Villa Royale, or any of the Old Town hole-in-the-wall noodle shops

S K I P

- Patong if you are over 25 and not actively looking for a hangover
- Tiger Kingdom, elephant rides, and anything that looks like animal tourism
- Tuk-tuks for any distance over 1km (they will charge you a hotel rate)
- Monsoon season unless you are getting a real discount and are okay with rain

M Y T A K E

*Stay on the **north-west coast**. Surin or Kamala. The hotels are better, the beaches are cleaner, and Patong is a 20-minute drive when you want it and invisible when you do not.*

THAILAND

Koh *Samui*

THE GULF ISLAND. COCONUT PALMS, FISHERMAN'S VILLAGE, THE OPPOSITE MONSOON.

Koh Samui is Thailand's third-largest island, sitting in the Gulf of Thailand on the east side of the country. It has a different rhythm to Phuket. Smaller, slower, more coconuts, fewer day boats, and crucially, a completely opposite monsoon pattern. When Phuket is wet, Samui is dry. That alone makes it worth knowing about.

Pick your beach. Chaweng is the main strip: longest beach, most restaurants, biggest nightlife, also the noisiest. Bophut is the smart pick for most: Fisherman's Village atmosphere, walkable, great dining, the calmest mix of beach and social. Lamai is Chaweng's quieter cousin to the south. Choeng Mon in the north is family-friendly and upscale. Maenam is the slowest, cheapest, and best if you want to disappear. The Four Seasons sits on its own private peninsula in the north, accessible only by hotel buggy.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Four Seasons Resort *Koh Samui*

Laem Yai · private peninsula, northwest tip

Sixty-plus pool villas on a private peninsula in the north of the island. Unobstructed Gulf views, calm private beach, the resort runs its own speedboat to Ang Thong Marine Park. Genuinely one of the great Four Seasons in Asia. Worth every dollar.

From ~\$900 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Resort+Koh+Samui](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Resort+Koh+Samui)

PREMIUM

Banyan Tree *Samui*

Lamai · private cove, hillside

All-pool-villa property tucked into a private cove on the south coast. Spectacular spa, dramatic infinity pools, hillside privacy. The honeymoon and couples pick. Quieter than the Four Seasons but with the same level of finish.

From ~\$500 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Banyan+Tree+Samui](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Banyan+Tree+Samui)

MID

Anantara Bophut *Koh Samui**Bophut · Fisherman's Village, beachfront*

Beachfront Anantara on the calm end of Bophut, walking distance to Fisherman's Village dining and the night market. Large rooms, big covered balconies that work even when it rains, classic Thai design. The smartest five-star value on the island.

From ~\$250 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Anantara+Bophut+Koh+Samui

SMART VALUE

Hansar *Samui**Bophut · Fisherman's Village, beachfront*

Adults-only boutique with enormous ocean-view balconies, a 30-second walk from Fisherman's Village restaurants and bars. The size of the balconies alone is worth the rate. Best Bophut mid-tier.

From ~\$140 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hansar+Samui

BACKPACKER

Lub d Koh Samui *Chaweng Beach**Chaweng · beachfront, central*

Beachfront hostel with private rooms and dorms, a social vibe, and an actual pool. The best budget option on the most convenient beach. Walk to all the bars and restaurants on Beach Road.

From ~\$30 / night (dorm), ~\$75 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Lub+d+Koh+Samui+Chaweng+Beach

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>January to April.</i> Dry season, calm seas, February is the driest month of the year.
WORST MONTHS	October and November. Peak monsoon, heavy rain, rough ferries, some properties basically shut down.
AIRPORT	Samui International (USM). Bangkok Airways runs most of the flights. Direct from BKK in just over an hour.
GET AROUND	Scooter is the local move. Songthaews (shared trucks) run fixed routes. Grab is patchy. Taxis are negotiated, not metered.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. 5 to 7 is the sweet spot.

DO

- + Ang Thong Marine Park day trip (the 42-island archipelago, the snorkeling is real)
- + Sunday night market at Fisherman's Village in Bophut
- + Big Buddha temple and Wat Plai Laem in the north
- + Coco Tams on Bophut beach for sunset cocktails on beanbags
- + Day trip to Koh Tao for diving if you have the time (2h fast boat from Maenam)

SKIP

- Hin Ta and Hin Yai (the grandfather and grandmother rocks). They are rocks shaped like genitals. Move on.
- Booking in October or November unless you genuinely do not care about weather
- Chaweng Beach Road hotels if you want sleep (the music does not stop until 3am)
- Cabarets that look like tourist traps. They are.

MY TAKE

*Samui's biggest underrated feature is the **reverse monsoon**. When the rest of Thailand is wet, Samui is mostly dry. If you are planning a Thailand trip in May, June or July and Phuket looks like a mess on the forecast, Samui is the answer.*

VIETNAM

Ho Chi Minh

SAIGON. MOTORBIKES, COFFEE, WAR HISTORY, BANH MI, ROOFTOPS, ENERGY.

Officially Ho Chi Minh City. Everyone still calls it Saigon. It is louder than Hanoi, faster than Hanoi, hotter than Hanoi, and it is the city Vietnam runs on. Ten million people, eight million motorbikes, the best coffee culture in Asia, and a colonial-French bone structure that the Vietnamese have completely repurposed for their own use.

Pick your district. District 1 is the center: most of the famous attractions, most of the hotels, most of the tourists. Within D1, the Dong Khoi area is upscale and walkable, Ben Thanh is around the famous market, and Bui Vien is the backpacker street that you visit for one night and never return to. District 3 next door is quieter, more local, with the better cafes. District 2 (Thao Dien) is the expat zone with the cleanest restaurants but a 15-minute Grab from everything historic. Stay in D1 for a first trip.

WHERE TO STAY

PREMIUM

The Reverie *Saigon**District 1 · Times Square, Nguyen Hue*

The most lavish hotel in the city. Italian-designed, deliberately maximalist, with one of the best spas and rooftop views in Saigon. Centrally located on Nguyen Hue walking street. Not understated. The flex hotel of HCMC.

From ~\$350 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Reverie+Saigon

MID

Hotel des Arts *Saigon**District 3 · 10 min walk to D1 attractions*

MGallery boutique with a strong art-house feel, rooftop pool, and a quieter D3 location that is still walkable to the War Remnants Museum and Notre Dame. The best balance of style and substance in the city.

From ~\$180 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+des+Arts+Saigon

SMART VALUE

La Siesta Premium *Saigon**District 1 · Ben Thanh, near the market*

The smartest five-star value in HCMC. Vietnamese La Siesta chain, opened 2023, boutique feel, full spa, two restaurants, four minutes from Ben Thanh Market. Punches way above the price.

From ~\$110 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=La+Siesta+Premium+Saigon

BACKPACKER

Duc Vuong *Saigon Hotel**District 1 · Bui Vien walking street*

Right in the middle of the backpacker action with a rooftop bar and rooms at the back that are surprisingly quiet. Clean, friendly, and walking distance to everything in D1. The right pick if you want to be where the energy is.

From ~\$40 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Duc+Vuong+Saigon+Hotel

BACKPACKER

Huong Sen *Hotel**District 1 · Dong Khoi Street*

Cheap rooms in the best street in the city. Steps from the Saigon River, the Opera House, and the Ho Chi Minh statue. Around the corner from The Reverie at one tenth the price. Lacks amenities but the location is unmatched at this budget.

From ~\$45 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Huong+Sen+Hotel+Saigon

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>December to March.</i> Dry season, cooler, the only time the heat is not punishing.
WORST MONTHS	May to October. Rainy season, daily afternoon downpours, peak humidity.
AIRPORT	Tan Son Nhat (SGN). 30 to 60 min to D1 depending on traffic. Use Grab, not taxi.
GET AROUND	Grab for everything. Walking inside D1. Crossing the road is its own skill, learn it.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 if doing Mekong or Cu Chi day trips.

DO

- + War Remnants Museum (heavy, essential, you will leave changed)
- + Banh mi at Banh Mi Huynh Hoa, pho at Pho Hoa Pasteur
- + Coffee at The Workshop, Phuc Long, or any cong ca phe location
- + Rooftop drinks at Chill Skybar, Saigon Saigon, or Social Club
- + Cu Chi Tunnels day trip (book the small-group, not the bus)

SKIP

- Bui Vien past midnight unless you are nineteen and reckless
- Cyclo tours pitched by strangers (they will overcharge)
- Cheap motorbike rentals if you have not ridden in Asia before
- The Saigon Notre Dame interior while it is under restoration

MY TAKE

Saigon rewards *two or three days*, not seven. See the museums, eat the food, do one day trip, then move on. Vietnam's real beauty is north and central, not in the south.

SOUTHEAST ASIA

Singapore

THE CITY-STATE. SKYSCRAPERS, HAWKER FOOD, GARDENS, THE CLEANEST STREETS YOU WILL SEE.

Singapore is a small island that decided to be a country, then decided to be the future. Five million people, a hundred-plus languages, the best public transport in Asia, and a hawker-food culture that has somehow stayed cheap despite everything else in the city being expensive.

Pick your area by what you want from the trip. Marina Bay is the postcard: Marina Bay Sands, Gardens by the Bay, the skyline. Stay here once in your life. Orchard Road is shopping and central transit. Sentosa is the resort-island play, useful for one or two nights of pool time. Chinatown and Kampong Glam have the cheaper hotels, better food, and the most character. The whole city is forty minutes end-to-end on the MRT, so location matters less here than in any other major city in Asia.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Marina Bay *Sands*

Marina Bay · the three-tower hotel with the boat on top

The most recognisable hotel on earth and the only reason most people know what Singapore looks like. The 57th-floor infinity pool with the skyline behind it is the defining hotel image of the century. The rooms are good, not great. You are paying for the pool. Worth doing once.

From ~\$600 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Marina+Bay+Sands+Singapore](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Marina+Bay+Sands+Singapore)

PREMIUM

Raffles *Singapore*

City Hall · colonial heart of the city

The other iconic Singapore hotel. 1887, all-suite, white colonial architecture, the Long Bar where the Singapore Sling was invented. Old-world service, candlelit courtyard dinners. If Marina Bay Sands is the future, Raffles is the past, and both are worth knowing.

From ~\$550 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Raffles+Hotel+Singapore](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Raffles+Hotel+Singapore)

MID

The Fullerton Bay *Hotel*

Marina Bay · harbourfront, smaller and quieter than the main Fullerton

Hundred-room boutique on the harbour with rooftop pool and the best night views of Marina Bay in the city. Smaller and more intimate than the main Fullerton. The right pick if you want the Marina Bay setting without paying Sands prices.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Fullerton+Bay+Hotel+Singapore

SMART VALUE

Hotel *Mono*

Chinatown · Mosque Street, walkable everywhere

Black-and-white minimalist boutique in restored Chinatown shophouses. Genuinely well-designed at a fair price, steps from Chinatown MRT, walking distance to the river and Marina Bay. The smartest mid-tier in the city.

From ~\$130 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Mono+Singapore

BACKPACKER

CUBE Boutique Capsule *Hotel*

Kampong Glam · near Bugis MRT

Capsule hotel done properly. Restored shophouse, clean pods with privacy blinds, modern bathrooms, a communal terrace and bar. Walking distance to Haji Lane food and Bugis transit. The best budget pick in Singapore.

From ~\$45 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=CUBE+Boutique+Capsule+Hotel+Kampong+Glam

BACKPACKER

Wink at *Mosque Street*

Chinatown · traditional shophouse, central

Hostel in a heritage shophouse with private rooms and dorms, a kitchen, laundry, and a small bar. Five-minute walk to Chinatown MRT, fifteen minutes to Clarke Quay. Clean, social, well run.

From ~\$50 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Wink+Mosque+Street+Singapore

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>February to April.</i> Driest months, manageable humidity, no major holidays driving prices up.
WORST MONTHS	November and December (heavy rain, peak holiday prices). June to August (haze season some years).
AIRPORT	Changi (SIN). Best airport in the world, full stop. 20 to 30 min to the city by MRT or taxi.
GET AROUND	MRT for everything. Grab for late nights. The city is small. Walking works for one or two stops.
STAY LENGTH	2 to 3 nights is the sweet spot. Anything more and you have run out of city.

DO

- + Gardens by the Bay at sunset, then the Supertree light show after dark
- + Hawker food at Maxwell, Lau Pa Sat, or Tiong Bahru Market
- + Marina Bay Sands SkyPark observation deck if you are not staying there
- + Chilli crab at Jumbo or No Signboard, once, even if you split it
- + Singapore Zoo or Night Safari if you have a third day

SKIP

- Sentosa as a main base unless you have kids or just want a pool
- Orchard Road shopping (you can buy these brands anywhere)
- Clarke Quay clubs unless you genuinely want to pay \$25 for a beer
- Renting a car. Public transit beats it for every single trip

MY TAKE

*Singapore is a **two or three night stop**, not a holiday. Combine it with Bali, KL, or Bangkok on either side. Treat it as the airport-and-skyline pause between two longer trips, and it works perfectly.*

JAPAN

Tokyo

THE BIG ONE. NEON, RAMEN, TRAINS, VENDING MACHINES, CIVILITY, SCALE.

Tokyo is bigger than any other city you have been to. Thirty-seven million people in the metro area. A subway system that makes London look amateur. The best food density on earth. And underneath all of it, a level of quiet civility that does not exist anywhere else at this scale.

Pick your district. Shinjuku is the classic first-timer base: enormous transit hub, neon at night, the Park Hyatt of Lost in Translation, west side for calm and east side for chaos. Shibuya is younger, trendier, the crossing, the bars, Hachiko. Ginza is the upscale shopping and Michelin density. Asakusa is old Tokyo with the Sensoji temple. Roppongi is foreign-friendly nightlife. Tokyo Station and Marunouchi is the cleanest central base, best for the Shinkansen onward to Kyoto. First trip, stay in Shinjuku or Shibuya.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Aman *Tokyo*

Otemachi · top six floors of a financial-district tower

Aman in a city tower. Massive rooms, the most dramatic atrium of any urban hotel anywhere, a 30-metre indoor pool with skyline views. Quiet, restrained, the opposite of Tokyo outside the door. The best urban Aman in the world.

From ~\$2,000 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Aman+Tokyo

PREMIUM

Park Hyatt *Tokyo*

West Shinjuku · top of Shinjuku Park Tower

The Lost in Translation hotel. Top 14 floors of a 52-story tower, the New York Bar on top, panoramic city views, Mount Fuji on clear days. The original Tokyo design hotel and still in the conversation for best in the city.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Park+Hyatt+Tokyo

M I D

Hotel *Indigo* Tokyo Shibuya*Shibuya · 8 min walk to the crossing*

Design-led boutique in the heart of Shibuya. Attentive staff, comfortable rooms, neighborhood character without the chain feel. The right pick if you want to wake up two minutes from the Shibuya energy.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Indigo+Tokyo+Shibuya

S M A R T V A L U E

Hotel Century *Southern Tower**Shinjuku · directly above Shinjuku Station south exit*

One of the best located hotels in the city. Directly above Shinjuku Station, which means you are one elevator away from every train line in Tokyo. Comfortable rooms, real city views, reliable Japanese mid-tier service.

From ~\$180 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Century+Southern+Tower+Shinjuku

B A C K P A C K E R

The Millennials *Shibuya**Shibuya · 5 min walk to the crossing*

Boutique capsule hotel that redefined the category. Pod-style smart rooms with full-size beds, free craft beer happy hour, communal kitchens and lounges. The right pick if you want a real Tokyo neighborhood at hostel pricing.

From ~\$55 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Millennials+Shibuya

B A C K P A C K E R

Nine Hours *Shinjuku**Shinjuku · steps from Shinjuku Station*

Capsule chain done with Japanese precision. Spotless pods, free toiletries, separate showers, the kind of place that makes you understand why budget travel in Japan is better than budget travel anywhere else.

From ~\$45 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nine+Hours+Shinjuku-North

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>Late March to early May</i> (cherry blossoms) and <i>October to November</i> (autumn leaves). Both are peak.
WORST MONTHS	June to mid-July (rainy season). August (brutal humidity).
AIRPORT	Narita (NRT) is far, 60 to 90 min by train. Haneda (HND) is close, 30 min. Choose Haneda if you can.
GET AROUND	JR Yamanote loop and Tokyo Metro for everything. Get an IC card on arrival. Taxis are expensive and rarely needed.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. 5 to 7 is right. The city is enormous.

DO

- + Tsukiji outer market for breakfast, then walk to the Tsukiji Hongwanji temple
- + Shibuya crossing at sunset, then a drink at the Mag's Park rooftop above it
- + Sensoji temple in Asakusa at sunrise, before the crowds
- + Omoide Yokocho or Golden Gai for tiny-bar dinner in Shinjuku
- + Sushi at one of the omakase counters in Tsukiji or Ginza (book ahead)

SKIP

- Tokyo Tower (Tokyo Skytree is better if you want a viewpoint)
- The Robot Restaurant. It closed years ago. The replacements are tourist traps.
- Trying to do day trips to Mt Fuji on a tour bus (rent a car or stay overnight in Hakone)
- August unless you genuinely have no other option

MY TAKE

Tokyo cannot be done in three days. People try. They leave exhausted, having seen ten percent. Give it a week. Walk a different neighborhood every day. Eat where the salarymen eat. The city opens up on day four.

JAPAN

Kyoto

THE OLD CAPITAL. TEMPLES, GARDENS, GEISHA, RYOKAN, THE SLOW SIDE OF JAPAN.

Kyoto is the Japan people imagined before they came to Japan. Two thousand temples, geisha districts that still function, the country's oldest restaurants, and a pace that is the opposite of Tokyo. If Tokyo is the future, Kyoto is the reason the future is worth visiting.

Pick your district. Southern Higashiyama is the temple zone: Kiyomizu-dera, Gion, the stone-paved lanes, all the famous hotels. Stay here if it is your first time. Downtown Kyoto around Karasuma and Kawaramachi is the most convenient for restaurants and shops. Arashiyama in the west is the bamboo forest and the riverside ryokan zone, beautiful but commuter-heavy if you base there. Kyoto Station is for transit nights and budget. Stay in Higashiyama or Downtown for the actual experience.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Aman *Kyoto*

Northern hills · private forest above Kinkaku-ji

Twenty-six pavilions and garden cottages in a private forest of cedar and moss. Designed by Kerry Hill. The garden alone is one of the best in Japan, and that is saying something. A forest onsen, kaiseki of the highest order, total seclusion. The hotel Kyoto was waiting for.

From ~\$2,200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Aman+Kyoto

PREMIUM

Park Hyatt *Kyoto*

Higashiyama · hillside, views of Yasaka Pagoda

Opened 2019 on the Higashiyama slope with rooms that look down over the Yasaka Pagoda and out across Kyoto. Seventy rooms, Michelin-starred kaiseki, private temple tours arranged by the concierge. The most coveted contemporary address in Kyoto.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Park+Hyatt+Kyoto

MID

The Celestine *Kyoto Gion**Gion · steps from the Yasaka Shrine*

Quietly excellent boutique in the heart of Gion. Tatami-style rooms, a small onsen, traditional Japanese service without the ryokan price tag. The smartest mid-tier in the city. Walkable to every temple in southern Higashiyama.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Celestine+Kyoto+Gion

SMART VALUE

Ace Hotel *Kyoto**Downtown · Karasuma, central Kyoto*

Kengo Kuma-designed Ace in a former 1920s telephone exchange. Vinyl players in the rooms, a great lobby bar, the best restaurant of any hotel in the city. The right pick if you want a base in the center, near both subway lines and the food scene.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Ace+Hotel+Kyoto

BACKPACKER

Piece Hostel *Sanjo**Downtown · 10 min walk from Gion*

Award-winning design hostel with private rooms and dorms, a small cafe, and a calm communal lounge. The right pick if you want the Downtown location at a fraction of the hotel price. Walk to Gion for sunset.

From ~\$50 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Piece+Hostel+Sanjo+Kyoto

BACKPACKER

Len Kyoto *Kawaramachi**Downtown · riverside, near Kawaramachi*

Hostel-cafe-bar hybrid by the Kamogawa river. Private rooms and dorms, a strong cafe by day, a real bar by night. Genuinely social without being a party hostel. Right in the middle of the best food and drink streets.

From ~\$55 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Len+Kyoto+Kawaramachi

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>Late March to early April</i> (cherry blossoms) and <i>November</i> (autumn leaves). Both are extraordinary, both are packed.
WORST MONTHS	July and August (humid, hot, the worst in Japan). Mid-June (rainy season).
AIRPORT	Closest is Osaka Kansai (KIX). 75 min by train. From Tokyo, take the Shinkansen, 2h 15min.
GET AROUND	Subway is limited. Bus network is good but slow. Taxis are reasonable. Walk Gion. Bicycle if you have time.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 is ideal.

DO

- + Fushimi Inari at sunrise (the only way to see it without 10,000 other people)
- + Kiyomizu-dera, then walk down Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka through old Gion
- + Arashiyama bamboo forest at 6am, before the buses
- + One night in a proper ryokan with kaiseki dinner, even if it is your only one
- + Tea ceremony in Gion or the Camellia tea house in Higashiyama

SKIP

- Geisha-spotting tours (it is invasive and most are not even geisha)
- The Bamboo Forest after 9am unless you enjoy crowds
- Kyoto Tower (it is a viewing platform on top of the train station, that is all)
- Cherry blossom season without booking 4 to 6 months ahead

MY TAKE

*Most of the famous Kyoto sights are best at **sunrise or sunset**, not midday. If you do nothing else in this city, set the alarm for 5am one morning and walk to a temple before the buses arrive. That is the Kyoto people come for.*

UAE · MIDDLE EAST

Dubai

THE DESERT CITY. SKYSCRAPERS, BEACH CLUBS, MALLS, BRUNCHES, LAYOVERS, AMBITION.

Dubai is what happens when a small port city in the desert decides to become a global hub in fifty years. Everything is new, everything is huge, and everything is built for visitors. It is divisive. Some people fall in love with it, some people leave hating it. Spend a few days and find out which one you are.

Pick your zone. Downtown is the Burj Khalifa, Dubai Mall, the fountain show, the spine of modern Dubai. Stay here for first time. Palm Jumeirah is the man-made island full of beach resorts: Atlantis, One&Only, Bulgari, the postcard view. Marina is high-rise residential with the JBR beach walk, good for younger crowds. Jumeirah Beach is where the heritage five-stars sit, including the Burj Al Arab. DIFC and Business Bay are the office districts, fine for work trips. If it is your first time, base Downtown for two nights and Palm for two more.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Burj Al *Arab*

Jumeirah Beach · the sail-shaped icon

The hotel that put Dubai on the map. All-suite, gold-leaf everywhere, butler service, the most over-the-top hotel experience on earth. Not subtle, not trying to be. Worth doing once if you have the budget, or going for afternoon tea or a drink if you do not.

From ~\$1,500 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Burj+Al+Arab+Dubai

PREMIUM

Four Seasons Resort *Dubai at Jumeirah Beach*

Jumeirah Beach · beachfront, calm side

The understated luxury play. Linen and palm trees, golden sand, a beach you actually want to lie on. The opposite of the spectacle hotels. Four Seasons service, real space, real calm. The most reliable five-star bet in the city.

From ~\$550 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Resort+Dubai+Jumeirah+Beach

MID

Atlantis *The Palm*

Palm Jumeirah · tip of the crescent

The family-resort answer. Aquaventure waterpark and the Lost Chambers aquarium on site, multiple restaurants including Nobu, the famous underwater suites. Less exclusive than Atlantis The Royal next door, but a third of the price. Best with kids or with people who want it all in one place.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Atlantis+The+Palm+Dubai

SMART VALUE

Rove *Downtown**Downtown · 10 min walk to Burj Khalifa*

Dubai's smartest budget-modern chain. Clean rooms, real pool, 24-hour gym, central Downtown location at hostel-plus pricing. The right pick if you are using the hotel as a base, not the destination. Multiple locations across the city.

From ~\$110 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Rove+Downtown+Dubai

BACKPACKER

Premier Inn *Dubai Al Jaddaf**Al Jaddaf · 15 min metro to Downtown*

The UK budget chain delivers in Dubai. Clean, predictable, free breakfast, walking distance to the metro. Not glamorous. Right for layovers, work trips, or first-time visitors who want to spend their money on experiences instead of the bed.

From ~\$60 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Premier+Inn+Dubai+Al+Jaddaf

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>November to March</i> . Cool season, 20 to 25C, the only time the heat is enjoyable.
WORST MONTHS	June to September. 40C plus, brutal humidity, beach is unusable in the day.
AIRPORT	Dubai International (DXB), 15 to 30 min to most hotels. Al Maktoum (DWC) handles some low-cost.
GET AROUND	Metro is good for the main spine. Careem and Uber for everything off it. Taxis are reasonable. Do not drive yourself, the highways are aggressive.
STAY LENGTH	3 to 5 nights. More and you have run out of city.

DO

- + Burj Khalifa observation deck (book At the Top SKY, not the basic level)
- + Desert safari with one of the better operators, sunset slot only
- + Brunch at Pierchic, Bvlgari, or one of the Palm hotel beach clubs
- + Old Dubai: the Gold Souk, Spice Souk, and an abra ride across the creek
- + Sunset at Pierchic or any rooftop with a Burj view

SKIP

- Visiting in July or August (you will not leave the air conditioning)
- The cheaper desert safaris (overcrowded camps, food poisoning risk)
- Renting a Lamborghini for Instagram (everyone does it, nobody cares)
- Friday brunches if you do not drink. Half the city shuts down for them.

MY TAKE

*Dubai is best as a **three-day stopover**, not a holiday. Stack it onto a longer trip to or from Europe, the Maldives, or Asia. Three days of brunches, beach clubs, and the Burj. Then leave before the city starts to feel like a shopping mall with a beach.*

TÜRKİYE

Istanbul

TWO CONTINENTS. MOSQUES, BAZAARS, THE BOSPHORUS, KEBABS, HAMMAMS, HISTORY.

Istanbul is the only major city in the world that sits on two continents. The European side has the history, the Asian side has the daily life. The Bosphorus runs between them, and ferries cross it constantly. It is one of the great cities on earth, and the Turkish lira's weakness against the dollar and euro means you get more hotel for your money here than almost anywhere in Europe.

Pick your side and your district. Sultanahmet (European, south of the Golden Horn) is the historic core: Hagia Sophia, Blue Mosque, Topkapi, Grand Bazaar all walkable. Stay here for first time. Beyoglu and Karakoy (European, north of the Golden Horn) is the modern city: Galata Tower, Istiklal Street, the rooftop bar scene, the design hotels. Kadikoy on the Asian side is local, untouristed, the best food. Most first trips split between Sultanahmet for two nights and Beyoglu for two more.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Four Seasons Hotel Istanbul at *Sultanahmet*

Sultanahmet · former Ottoman prison, steps from Hagia Sophia

A 1918 Ottoman prison converted into a 65-room Four Seasons. The setting is unmatched: courtyard rooms, hammam-style spa, Hagia Sophia visible from the rooftop. The benchmark luxury hotel in the old city and one of the most atmospheric Four Seasons anywhere.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Sultanahmet+Istanbul

PREMIUM

Pera Palace *Hotel*

Beyoglu · 1892 building, Galata Tower district

The hotel built for passengers off the Orient Express. Agatha Christie wrote *Murder on the Orient Express* in room 411, which you can book. Belle Époque restoration, the original elevator, the original tea salon. The modern city's most historic address.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pera+Palace+Hotel+Istanbul

MID

10 *Karakoy**Karakoy · waterfront, near Galata Bridge*

Design-led boutique by Morgans Hotel Group veterans. Industrial-loft interiors, rooftop bar with Bosphorus views, the kind of place that makes you understand why Karakoy is now the cool neighborhood. Walkable to Galata and to the ferry.

From ~\$180 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=10+Karakoy+Istanbul

SMART VALUE

Sirkeci *Mansion**Sirkeci · 10 min walk to Hagia Sophia*

The smartest mid-range in Sultanahmet. A boutique mansion property with a rooftop terrace looking at Hagia Sophia and the Bosphorus, free Turkish hammam access, hands-down friendly service. Punches way above the price.

From ~\$110 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Sirkeci+Mansion+Istanbul

BACKPACKER

Hotel *Amira* Istanbul*Sultanahmet · 5 min walk to Blue Mosque*

Small family-run boutique right in the historic core. Friendly staff, real Turkish breakfast on the rooftop terrace, walking distance to every major sight. The right pick if you want one good budget hotel in the middle of everything.

From ~\$60 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Amira+Istanbul

BACKPACKER

Cheers *Hostel**Sultanahmet · 5 min walk to Hagia Sophia*

The reliable social hostel in the old town. Private rooms and dorms, a rooftop bar with views of Hagia Sophia, helpful staff who organise free walking tours. Best budget option if you want to meet other travellers.

From ~\$25 / night (dorm), ~\$55 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Cheers+Hostel+Sultanahmet+Istanbul

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>April to June</i> and <i>September to October</i> . Spring and autumn. Mild weather, manageable crowds.
WORST MONTHS	July and August (hot, packed). December to February (cold, grey, but cheap).
AIRPORT	Istanbul Airport (IST) is the main hub, 45 to 75 min to central. Sabiha Gokcen (SAW) on the Asian side handles low-cost.
GET AROUND	Tram is the main spine through the old city. Ferries between the European and Asian sides are essential. Walk Sultanahmet and Beyoglu. Use Bolt for everything else.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 is ideal.

DO

- + Hagia Sophia and the Blue Mosque early morning (different rules now, dress respectfully)
- + Topkapi Palace and the Basilica Cistern in the same morning
- + Bosphorus ferry from Eminonu, all the way to Anadolu Kavagi and back
- + Turkish hammam at Cagaloglu or Suleymaniye (the historic ones, not the hotel spas)
- + Eat at Karakoy Lokantasi, Mikla, or any kebab shop in Kadikoy

SKIP

- Carpet shop "tours" pitched by friendly men outside the Blue Mosque
- Shoeshine-drop scams (man drops his brush, you pick it up, he charges you)
- Restaurants right on Istiklal or next to the Grand Bazaar (tourist menus)
- Trying to do Istanbul in two days. You will see nothing.

MY TAKE

*The cheap currency in Istanbul means you can stay in **better hotels than you can afford anywhere else in Europe**. Spend the money you save here on rooftop dinners, hammam visits, and the long Bosphorus ferry. That is the city's whole gift to you.*

FINLAND · NORTHERN EUROPE

Helsinki

THE DESIGN CAPITAL. SAUNAS, SEA, NEOCLASSICAL STREETS, LONG SUMMER LIGHT.

Helsinki is the smallest of the Nordic capitals and the quietest. Six hundred thousand people, a harbor that freezes in winter, the world's best public sauna culture, and the cleanest, most considered design culture in Europe. It is not a wild city. It is a thinking person's city.

Pick your area. Kamppi and the central grid around Esplanadi Park is where everything sits: hotels, restaurants, the harbor, the cathedral. Stay here. Punavuori to the south is the Design District: independent shops, galleries, the best cafes. Kallio across the bay is the bohemian neighborhood with the cheaper bars. The whole city is walkable in an hour. You can also ferry to Suomenlinna island fortress from the harbor, which you should.

WHERE TO STAY

PREMIUM

Hotel *Kämp*

Esplanadi · 1887, opposite Esplanade park

Finland's grand hotel since 1887. The bar where Sibelius composed, the gilded ballroom, suites of Biedermeier grandeur. The city's most historically significant address and still the best service in Finland. Walking distance to everything that matters.

From ~\$400 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Kamp+Helsinki](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Kamp+Helsinki)

MID

St. *George* Helsinki

City Centre · 19th-century building, walking distance to everything

Art-led boutique with over 400 contemporary pieces hanging through the building, a serious spa with rooftop terrace, and rooms that feel like staying in a small gallery. Quietly the most considered luxury hotel in Helsinki.

From ~\$280 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+St+George+Helsinki](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+St+George+Helsinki)

MID · BOUTIQUE

Hotel *F6**Design District · Fredrikinkatu*

Small boutique on a quiet courtyard in the Design District. Finnish craft furniture throughout, an in-house sauna (of course), and the kind of restaurant that anchors the local food scene. Reliably one of the best stays in Finland at a fair price.

From ~\$200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+F6+Helsinki

SMART VALUE

Scandic Grand *Central* Helsinki*Central Station · directly opposite the main station*

Inside the historic 1909 station building, completely renovated. Scandic's reliable Nordic mid-tier service, big rooms by European standards, a good sauna, and you literally cannot have a more central location. Practical, polished, fair priced.

From ~\$140 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Scandic+Grand+Central+Helsinki

BACKPACKER

Eurohostel *Helsinki**Katajanokka · 10 min walk to Market Square*

The biggest hostel in the city, simple private rooms and dorms, free morning sauna, central location near the ferry terminal. Clean, well-run, the most affordable real bed in central Helsinki.

From ~\$55 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Eurohostel+Helsinki

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS *June to August.* Long days, the city spills outdoors, harbor sauna season.
December for Christmas markets and snow.

WORST MONTHS November and February. Grey, short days, the worst light of the year.

AIRPORT Helsinki-Vantaa (HEL). 30 min by train (the airport rail link is excellent).

GET AROUND Tram is the move. Public transit is honest and easy. Walk the city center.

STAY LENGTH 2 to 3 nights is right. Pair with Tallinn or Stockholm by overnight ferry.

D O

- + Loyly or Allas Sea Pool for a proper Finnish sauna experience
- + Suomenlinna fortress by ferry, give it a half day
- + Esplanade Park and Senate Square on a sunny morning
- + Eat at Olo, Savotta, or any salmon-and-rye place in the Old Market Hall
- + Day trip ferry to Tallinn (2 hours each way, easy to do as a single day)

S K I P

- Tourist saunas in hotel basements (go to a real public one)
- Visiting in late November when there are five hours of grey daylight
- Renting a car for the city (everything is walking or tram distance)
- Helsinki Card unless you are doing more than five museums

M Y T A K E

*Helsinki on its own is a **two-night trip**. Helsinki paired with the Tallinn ferry and a long weekend across the gulf is one of the most underrated short trips in Europe. Do both, not one.*

ESTONIA · BALTIC

Tallinn

THE MEDIEVAL ONE. COBBLESTONES, TOWERS, CHEAP BEER, THE BEST PRESERVED OLD TOWN IN EUROPE.

Tallinn is what people imagine when they think medieval Europe. A walled Old Town, cobblestone lanes, towers and turrets, restaurants serving food in cellars under 700-year-old buildings. It is also half the price of anywhere in Western Europe, which is why it works as a weekend or as the second half of a Helsinki trip.

Pick your zone. The Old Town (Vanalinn) is the whole point. Stay inside the walls. Within the Old Town, Lower Town has the bigger hotels and the main square (Raekoja plats), and Toompea above it has the viewpoints and the cathedrals. Kalamaja just outside the walls is the creative neighborhood: hipster cafes, the Telliskivi creative district, ferry-line access. If you have two nights, do one in Old Town and one in Kalamaja. If you have one night, stay in the Old Town.

WHERE TO STAY

PREMIUM

Hotel *Telegraaf*

Old Town · former 19th-century telegraph office

Marriott Autograph Collection in a beautifully restored 19th-century telegraph office, deep in the Old Town. Indoor pool, Turkish steam bath, real spa, a great rooftop in summer. The best hotel in Tallinn, full stop.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Telegraaf+Tallinn

MID

Schlössle *Hotel*

Old Town · 13th-century building, off the main square

Small Luxury Hotels of the World property inside a 13th-century medieval building. Twenty-three rooms, original beams, candlelit cellar restaurant, the kind of place where the building itself is the experience. The atmospheric pick.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Schlossle+Hotel+Tallinn

SMART VALUE

Nunne Boutique *Hotel**Old Town · Nunne Street, near Raekoja plats*

Smart small boutique inside the walls. Clean, modern rooms in a restored townhouse, great staff, a proper breakfast. Punches above its price and is right in the middle of everything you came to see.

From ~\$120 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nunne+Boutique+Hotel+Tallinn

SMART VALUE · UNIQUE

Iglupark *Tallinn**Noblessner Marina · Baltic Sea, Kalamaja side*

Igloo-style sea-facing huts on the harbor in Kalamaja. You sleep in a small dome with a glass front looking at the Baltic. Not a normal hotel. The best photogenic stay in the city if you want one night that is not in a building older than your country.

From ~\$130 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Iglupark+Tallinn

BACKPACKER

Old Town Munkenhof *Guesthouse**Old Town · inside the walls*

Tiny family-run guesthouse inside the medieval walls. Small basic rooms with character to spare, winding staircases, uneven floors, the whole medieval thing. Spotless and cheap and exactly what you came to Tallinn for.

From ~\$50 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Old+Town+Munkenhof+Tallinn

BACKPACKER

Citybox *Tallinn* City Center*5 min walk from Old Town*

Scandinavian budget chain with self-check-in pods, compact modern rooms, fast Wi-Fi, no frills. The cleanest, most reliable budget hotel option in central Tallinn. Great for solo travellers who do not want a hostel.

From ~\$40 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Citybox+Tallinn+City+Center

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to September.</i> Long daylight, outdoor cafes open, the Old Town at its photogenic best.
WORST MONTHS	November to February. Cold and dark. Charming in December for Christmas markets, otherwise grim.
AIRPORT	Lennart Meri Tallinn Airport (TLL). 15 min by tram or taxi to central.
GET AROUND	Walk. The Old Town is small enough that you do not need anything else. Tram for the airport and Kalamaja.
STAY LENGTH	2 nights. Long weekend with Helsinki is the ideal pairing.

DO

- + Walk the city walls and climb a couple of the towers (Kiek in de K  k is worth it)
- + Lunch at Olde Hansa or Peppersack for the full medieval-cellar tourist thing once
- + Telliskivi Creative City in Kalamaja for the cafes, design shops, and the food street
- + Ferry day trip to Helsinki if you have not done it the other way
- + Sunset from Kohtuotsa viewing platform on Toompea

SKIP

- Stag-do bars on Viru Street (the British have ruined that one corner)
- The Estonian-cuisine restaurants pitched at cruise-ship day trippers
- Renting a car if you are only staying in Tallinn
- Skipping Kalamaja just because it is outside the walls

MY TAKE

*Tallinn is a **two-night city**, not a week. Pair it with Helsinki by ferry, or string it into a longer Baltic trip with Riga and Vilnius. As a standalone destination it is too small. As part of a route, it is one of the best stops in Europe.*

DENMARK · NORTHERN EUROPE

Copenhagen

THE DESIGN CAPITAL. BICYCLES, HARBOR SWIMS, NORDIC FOOD, HYGGE, RESTRAINT.

Copenhagen is the cleanest, best-organised, most quietly confident city in Europe. The cycling infrastructure is the best in the world. The food scene anchors itself with Noma at the top. The design culture is woven into everything, including hotel architecture, which is why the hotels here punch above their weight at every price level. It is expensive, but you understand why.

Pick your district. Indre By (Inner City) is the center: Nyhavn, the canals, the main shopping streets, the grand hotels. Stay here for first time. Vesterbro is the trendy reformed-meatpacking district, walking distance to the center, with the design hotels and the best new restaurants. Nørrebro is the bohemian-cool neighborhood, slightly out but worth a base if you have already done the center. Christianshavn across the harbor has Christiania, the canal houses, and Noma. The city is small. Anywhere central works.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Hotel *d'Angleterre*

Kongens Nytorv · 1755, the main square

Copenhagen's grand hotel since 1755. Two Michelin Keys, Michelin-starred restaurant Marchal, the Champagne Bar with vintages from 42 houses. The hotel that has hosted royalty and Tchaikovsky and Marlene Dietrich. Old-world elegance with serious modern execution.

From ~\$700 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+d+Angleterre+Copenhagen](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+d+Angleterre+Copenhagen)

PREMIUM

Nimb *Hotel*

Tivoli Gardens · Moorish 1909 building

38 individually decorated rooms inside Tivoli Gardens, with VIP access to the park. Fairytale Moorish architecture, an emerald rooftop pool, five restaurants. Magical in December when Tivoli lights up. The most unique hotel in Northern Europe.

From ~\$550 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nimb+Hotel+Copenhagen](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nimb+Hotel+Copenhagen)

MID

Villa *Copenhagen**Vesterbro · former Central Post Office*

390-room hotel inside the magnificent late-19th-century Central Post Office building. The original postal hall is now the lobby. Rooftop pool with city panorama, the best warm-weather hotel terrace in town. Delivers a comparable design experience to d'Angleterre at meaningfully less.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Villa+Copenhagen

MID · BOUTIQUE

Hotel *Sanders**Indre By · steps from Nyhavn*

Small design hotel by a former Royal Danish Ballet dancer. Velvet, brass, palm prints, and a rooftop terrace one block from Nyhavn. Personal, intimate, and absolutely the most photogenic boutique in Copenhagen.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Sanders+Copenhagen

SMART VALUE

Coco *Hotel**Vesterbro · 10 min walk to Central Station*

Parisian-inspired eco-conscious boutique in Vesterbro. 89 rooms around a leafy courtyard, a popular all-day cafe and wine bar that locals actually use. Carbon-negative, plastic-free, and the smartest mid-budget play in the city.

From ~\$170 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Coco+Hotel+Copenhagen

BACKPACKER

Generator *Copenhagen**Indre By · between Nørreport and Kongens Nytorv*

The design-hostel chain's Copenhagen flagship. Private rooms and dorms, a busy lobby bar and cafe, real design throughout. Walking distance to Nyhavn, the lakes, and the main shopping streets. The best budget bet in central Copenhagen.

From ~\$50 / night (dorm), ~\$120 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Generator+Copenhagen

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to August.</i> Long daylight, outdoor dining, harbor swimming, the city in its best mood.
WORST MONTHS	November and January (dark and grey). December is cold but worth it for Tivoli and the Christmas markets.
AIRPORT	Copenhagen (CPH). 15 min by metro to central. One of the easiest airport-to-city transfers in Europe.
GET AROUND	Bicycle. The cycling infrastructure is the best in the world. Most hotels offer free bikes. Use them.
STAY LENGTH	3 to 4 nights. Pair with Malmö across the bridge for an extra day.

DO

- + Rent a bike on day one, use it for everything
- + Swim at La Banchina or Sandkaj harbor baths in summer
- + Tivoli Gardens at night (open mid-April to September and December)
- + Eat at Noma if you can get a table, Geist or Höst if you cannot
- + Day trip to Louisiana Museum of Modern Art (35 min by train, worth it)

SKIP

- The Little Mermaid statue. It is small and you will be disappointed.
- Taxis. You will lose money. The bikes and metro do everything.
- Nyhavn restaurants right on the canal (tourist prices, mediocre food)
- Visiting Christiania for the wrong reasons

MY TAKE

*Copenhagen is the city that **makes you reconsider your own city.** The cycling, the food, the design, the public swimming spots in the harbor. You leave thinking, why does everywhere else not work like this.*

UK · WESTERN EUROPE

London

THE CAPITAL. PUBS, PARKS, THEATRE, MARKETS, TAXIS, WEATHER, HISTORY.

London is the most varied city in Europe. Twelve million people, dozens of neighborhoods that each feel like their own town, the best theatre scene on earth, the worst weather, and a hotel market deeper than anywhere else in the world. Whatever you want from a city, London has it. The trick is picking the right corner.

Pick your neighborhood. Mayfair (W1, west) is the heritage luxury zone: Claridge's, The Connaught, the grand hotels, the high-end shopping. Soho and Covent Garden are theatre, restaurants, nightlife, walkable everything. Shoreditch (East) is the trendy creative neighborhood with the design hotels. South Kensington and Marylebone are central and calm, great for first-timers who want to be safe and walk to museums. Stay west or central for first trip. Stay east if you want the scene.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Claridge's

Mayfair · Brook Street

London's grand dame since the 1850s. Art Deco glamour, the most discreet butler service in the city, the lobby tea that everyone wants to be photographed having. The hotel celebrities pick for privacy. Once-in-a-lifetime stay.

From ~\$1,200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Claridges+London

PREMIUM

The *Connaught*

Mayfair · Carlos Place

Two Michelin stars in the restaurant, the best bar in the world (Connaught Bar) downstairs, and a level of service so quiet you barely notice it happening. The discreet alternative to Claridge's. Slightly less famous, slightly more refined.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Connaught+London

PREMIUM

The *Ned*

City of London · former Midland Bank HQ

Soho House group's grand-hotel play inside a 1920s bank. Eight restaurants in the lobby, a members' rooftop with pool, club-like energy without being a club. Stay here if you want to feel like you've stepped into a film.

From ~\$500 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Ned+London

MID

The *Hoxton* Holborn*Holborn · between Soho and the City*

The reliable design boutique that punches above its tier. Big lobby, great cafe-bar, walkable to Soho and the West End. The smartest mid-range hotel in central London.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Hoxton+Holborn+London

SMART VALUE

The *July* Victoria*Victoria · steps from Victoria Station*

Apartment-hotels opened 2025 by the Amsterdam Zoku team. Smeg kitchens, king beds, all the freedom of an Airbnb with none of the host notes. The best fair-priced option for a 3+ night stay in central London.

From ~\$200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+July+Victoria+London

BACKPACKER

Generator *London**Russell Square · near King's Cross*

Design-hostel chain's flagship in a former police barracks. Private rooms and dorms, a lively bar, walkable to King's Cross and the British Museum. The best budget choice that does not feel like budget.

From ~\$45 / night (dorm), ~\$130 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Generator+London

BACKPACKER

YHA London *Central**Marylebone · Great Portland Street*

Reliable mid-budget hostel option in zone 1. Clean private rooms and dorms, friendly staff, walking distance to Oxford Street and Regent's Park. The right pick if you want central London at hostel money.

From ~\$40 / night (dorm), ~\$110 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=YHA+London+Central

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to September.</i> Long days, parks open, beer gardens working. September the sweet spot.
WORST MONTHS	November to February. Cold, grey, dark by 4pm. Christmas markets are the one upside.
AIRPORT	Heathrow (LHR) is the main hub. Gatwick, Stansted, Luton for low-cost. Use the Tube or Express, not taxis from the airport.
GET AROUND	Tube and bus. Get an Oyster card or use contactless. Walking is good in central. Black cabs for late nights.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. London needs a week to make sense.

DO

- + Tate Modern, British Museum, V&A. They are all free.
- + A West End show. Get tickets at the TKTS booth in Leicester Square day-of.
- + Sunday roast at The Camberwell Arms, Quality Chop House, or any decent pub
- + Walk Regent's Canal from King's Cross to Camden
- + Borough Market for lunch, Columbia Road flower market on Sunday morning

SKIP

- The London Eye unless you have kids (overpriced for a slow Ferris wheel)
- Madame Tussauds (genuinely pointless)
- Restaurants in Leicester Square (tourist traps without exception)
- Renting a car. You will hate it. Public transit is the best in Europe.

MY TAKE

*London is the only city in Europe where you can have **five different kinds of trip in the same week**. Pick one focus per visit. Museums and theatre, or food and pubs, or East London creative, or West End luxury. Trying to do all of it leaves you with a blur.*

FRANCE · WESTERN EUROPE

Paris

THE CAPITAL. CAFES, MUSEUMS, BREAD, WINE, THE RIVER, THE LIGHT.

Paris is the most photographed city in the world for good reason. The Seine, the Haussmann boulevards, the cafe culture, the food, the museums. It is also smaller than people expect and easier to navigate than any other major European capital. A week is enough to see most of it. A weekend is enough to fall for it.

Pick your arrondissement. The 1st (Louvre, Tuileries, Place Vendôme) has the grand hotels and the postcard views. The 3rd and 4th (the Marais) have the best boutique hotels, the best shopping, and the most walkable charm. The 6th (Saint-Germain) is classic literary-cafe Paris on the Left Bank. The 18th (Montmartre) is the hilltop artistic neighborhood with the views. First trip, the Marais. Second trip, anywhere else.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Le *Bristol* Paris

8th · Rue du Faubourg Saint-Honoré

The most consistently brilliant grand hotel in Paris. Three Michelin stars in the restaurant, a rooftop pool shaped like a wooden yacht, the resident hotel cat Fa-raon. Old money, real service, no fuss. The benchmark.

From ~\$1,400 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Le+Bristol+Paris

PREMIUM

Ritz *Paris*

1st · Place Vendôme

The most famous hotel name in the world, on the most famous square. Hemingway Bar, the suite Coco Chanel lived in for thirty years, the most photographed lobby in Europe. Spectacular, slightly performative, worth doing once.

From ~\$1,200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Ritz+Paris

MID · BOUTIQUE

Hôtel du Petit *Moulin**Marais · 3rd, near rue Charlot*

Christian Lacroix-designed boutique in the old Paris bakery from the time of Henry IV. Seventeen rooms, each completely different, all unmistakably theatrical. The Marais boutique experience at full intensity.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+du+Petit+Moulin+Paris

MID · BOUTIQUE

Hôtel de *JoBo**Marais · 4th, near Place des Vosges*

A floral, romantic, completely Marais boutique with rooms inspired by Empress Joséphine. Twenty-four rooms, courtyard hammam, a hidden cocktail bar in the basement. The most photographed boutique in Paris right now.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+de+JoBo+Paris

SMART VALUE

Hôtel *Sookie**9th · between Pigalle and Saint-Georges*

Earthy modernist boutique with stone, bamboo, textured carpets, and rooms that feel one-of-a-kind. Walkable to Montmartre and to the 2nd. The smartest design-led mid-price hotel in Paris.

From ~\$180 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Sookie+Paris

BACKPACKER

Generator *Paris**10th · near Canal Saint-Martin*

Design hostel near the Canal Saint-Martin scene. Big bar, rooftop terrace, walking distance to République and Gare du Nord. Best social budget option in the city.

From ~\$45 / night (dorm), ~\$130 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Generator+Paris

BACKPACKER

Les *Piaules**Belleville · 20th, near the canal*

The Parisian-cool hostel with a rooftop bar that draws locals on Friday nights. Clean private rooms and dorms, a real cafe downstairs. Best for travellers who want the local-Paris side over the postcard side.

From ~\$40 / night (dorm), ~\$100 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Les+Piaules+Belleville+Paris

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>April to June</i> and <i>September to October</i> . Mild, walkable, the gardens at their best.
WORST MONTHS	August (locals leave, many places shut). November to February (cold, grey).
AIRPORT	Charles de Gaulle (CDG) is the main hub. Orly (ORY) is closer and easier. Use RER or Roissybus, not taxi from CDG.
GET AROUND	Metro for everything. Walk in central. Bikes (Vélib') are good when the weather allows.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 4 to 5 is ideal.

DO

- + The Louvre, the Musée d'Orsay, the Picasso Museum. Book online ahead.
- + Walk the Seine from Notre-Dame to the Eiffel Tower at sunset
- + Eat at any neighborhood bistro that has handwritten menus and locals inside
- + Aperitif on a cafe terrace before dinner. This is the actual Paris.
- + Day trip to Versailles or stay-in-town picnic in the Jardin du Luxembourg

SKIP

- Eiffel Tower at the top of the hour (twelve-thousand people, four-hour queue)
- The crepe stands and onion-soup tourist menus on Île de la Cité
- The Lock Bridge unless you enjoy disappointment (the locks are gone)
- Pickpocket-heavy metro lines 1 and 9 at peak times. Watch your bag.

MY TAKE

*Paris is the city that rewards **not having a plan**. The set itinerary trips (Louvre / Eiffel / Notre-Dame in three days) leave people hating Paris. Just walk. Sit at cafes. Eat where the queues are local, not foreign. The city does the rest.*

NETHERLANDS · WESTERN EUROPE

Amsterdam

THE CANAL CITY. BICYCLES, GABLED HOUSES, MUSEUMS, BROWN CAFES, CALM.

Amsterdam is the small European capital that punches above its weight on almost every metric. UNESCO canal belt, the Rijksmuseum, the Van Gogh, the cycling infrastructure that makes you furious at your own city. Walkable end to end in an afternoon and full of the best canal-house hotels in the world.

Pick your zone. The Canal Belt (Grachtengordel) is the postcard: 17th-century gabled houses, the famous canals, the prettiest streets. Stay here for first time. Jordaan is the quieter, more residential pocket of the same belt with the cosy "brown cafes" and Anne Frank House. De Pijp is the trendy, lively southern neighborhood. Centrum near Centraal Station is convenient but the Red Light District is right there, which is something to know. First trip, stay in the Canal Belt or Jordaan.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Rosewood *Amsterdam*

Canal Belt · former Palace of Justice on the Prinsengracht

Opened 2024 in the former Palace of Justice on the canal. Rosewood at the absolute top of its game: monumental architecture, two restaurants by Michelin-starred chefs, a spa in the old vaults. Already the most talked-about hotel in Northern Europe.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Rosewood+Amsterdam

PREMIUM

Waldorf Astoria *Amsterdam*

Canal Belt · Herengracht, six 17th-century canal houses

Six restored 17th-century canal houses on the Herengracht, with a hidden garden you cannot believe is in central Amsterdam. The most quietly luxurious hotel in the city. Genuine canal-house experience at full Waldorf level.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Waldorf+Astoria+Amsterdam

M I D

Pulitzer Amsterdam*Canal Belt · 25 connected canal houses on Prinsengracht*

The largest canal-house hotel in the city, 25 interconnected 17th-century homes between the Prinsengracht and Keizersgracht. Beautifully restored, full of original detail, a maze in the best way. The most quintessential Amsterdam hotel experience at this price.

From ~\$400 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pulitzer+Amsterdam

M I D · B O U T I Q U E

The Hoxton Herengracht*Canal Belt · 9 Streets neighborhood*

Hoxton in five canal houses in the heart of the 9 Streets shopping district. Big lobby, great restaurant, the cheapest stylish way to wake up on a canal. The reliable design pick.

From ~\$250 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Hoxton+Herengracht+Amsterdam

S M A R T V A L U E

Sir Albert*De Pijp · former diamond factory*

Contemporary boutique in a 19th-century diamond factory in De Pijp. Loft-feel rooms, great restaurant, walking distance to the Albert Cuyp market. Best mid-budget pick if you want to stay outside the Canal Belt without losing the design.

From ~\$170 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Sir+Albert+Hotel+Amsterdam

B A C K P A C K E R

Generator Amsterdam*Oosterpark · 10 min tram to centre*

Inside the former zoology building in Oosterpark. Design hostel with private rooms and dorms, restaurant, lively bar. Best social budget pick. Slightly out of the centre but easy on the tram.

From ~\$50 / night (dorm), ~\$140 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Generator+Amsterdam

BACKPACKER

ClinkNOORD

Amsterdam Noord · 5 min ferry from Centraal

Massive design hostel across the IJ in Amsterdam Noord. Free ferry from Centraal, a great bar, walking distance to the EYE Film Museum and the A'DAM lookout tower. Cheapest decent option in the city.

From ~\$35 / night (dorm), ~\$95 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=ClinkN00RD+Amsterdam

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>April to June</i> (tulips and good weather) and <i>September</i> . Avoid King's Day (April 27) unless that is the trip.
WORST MONTHS	November to February. Wet, cold, short days. Christmas markets and ice skating are the upside.
AIRPORT	Schiphol (AMS). 15 min direct train to Centraal Station. One of the easiest airport-city transfers in the world.
GET AROUND	Bicycle. Get a rental on day one. Trams for distances. Walking inside the canal belt.
STAY LENGTH	2 to 3 nights is the sweet spot. 4 if combining museums and day trips.

DO

- + Rijksmuseum (book ahead, give it 3 hours, see the Vermeers)
- + Anne Frank House (book online weeks ahead, this is non-negotiable)
- + Bike around Vondelpark, then south through Oud-Zuid
- + Eat at Foodhallen, then drink in a brown cafe in the Jordaan
- + Day trip to Haarlem or the Zaanse Schans windmills

SKIP

- Wandering the Red Light District at night for the sake of it
- Coffee shops if you do not actually want to use them (it is not a tourist photo op)
- Renting a car. You will never need it. Cycling is the answer to everything.
- Restaurants on the main canal corners (tourist traps, expensive, average)

MY TAKE

*Amsterdam is best as a **two or three night stop on a wider European trip**. Pair it with Bruges, Antwerp, or Cologne by train, or use it as your gateway into Northern Europe. As a standalone trip the city is small enough to feel finished after three days.*

MOROCCO · NORTH AFRICA

Marrakech

THE RED CITY. SOUKS, RIADS, THE DESERT, MINT TEA, SNAKE CHARMERS, SUNSETS.

Marrakech is the most sensory city in this whole guide. The medina walls glow red. The call to prayer comes five times a day. The souks are a labyrinth of leather and silver and spices. The riad hotels are some of the best small-scale luxury experiences anywhere on earth. Three days here changes how you think about cities.

Pick your zone. The Medina (the old walled city) is the historic core: souks, Jemaa el-Fnaa square, traditional riads. Stay here for the experience. The Hivernage and Gueliz (the new city) is the modern district: cocktail bars, malls, the international hotels. Outside the city, the Palmeraie has the resort hotels with pools and gardens, 15 to 30 min from the medina. First trip, stay in a medina riad for at least two nights.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Royal *Mansour* Marrakech

Medina edge · 53 private riads inside the hotel

The hotel built by King Mohammed VI as a personal project. Not rooms. Not suites. Fifty-three private three-storey riads, each with a courtyard, a roof terrace with private pool, and butler service. Underground service tunnels so staff are never seen. The most extraordinary hotel in Africa.

From ~\$1,800 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Royal+Mansour+Marrakech

PREMIUM

La *Mamounia*

Medina edge · Avenue Bab Jdid

The grand hotel since 1923. Eight acres of gardens inside the medina walls, Churchill's favourite hotel, fully renovated by Yves Saint Laurent and now by Jouin Manku. The most consistently great service in Morocco. The classic Marrakech splurge.

From ~\$800 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=La+Mamounia+Marrakech

MID · BOUTIQUE

El *Fenn**Medina · 5 min walk from Jemaa el-Fnaa*

Vanessa Branson's painterly riad hotel and easily the most stylish boutique in the medina. Forty-one rooms across nine connected riads, a rooftop pool with views over the medina, an art collection that rotates through the hotel. The riad experience at full design intensity.

From ~\$400 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=El+Fenn+Marrakech

SMART VALUE

Riad *Yasmine**Medina · north medina, quieter quarter*

Eight rooms around a courtyard pool fringed with banana trees. The Instagram-famous green-tiled pool is the photo, but the hotel is more than that. Personal service, set Moroccan dinners on the rooftop, the experience of a real riad at a fair price.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Riad+Yasmine+Marrakech

BACKPACKER

Riad *BE* Marrakech*Medina · 10 min walk from Jemaa el-Fnaa*

Boutique-budget riad with the same courtyard-and-rooftop format as the expensive places, at a fraction of the price. Private rooms, friendly staff, included breakfast on the roof. The smartest cheap riad in the medina.

From ~\$60 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Riad+BE+Marrakech

BACKPACKER

Equity Point *Marrakech**Medina · steps from Jemaa el-Fnaa*

The reliable social hostel for the Marrakech stop. Private rooms and dorms inside a converted riad, rooftop terrace, pool, included breakfast. Walking distance to the main square. Best budget option if you want to meet other travellers.

From ~\$20 / night (dorm), ~\$55 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Equity+Point+Marrakech

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>March to May</i> and <i>September to November</i> . Spring and autumn. Warm days, cool nights, the souks at their best.
WORST MONTHS	July and August (40C+, brutal). December and January (cool nights, sometimes cold).
AIRPORT	Marrakech Menara (RAK). 15 min to the medina. Use the hotel transfer.
GET AROUND	Walking inside the medina (cars cannot really enter). Petit taxis for outside the walls. Negotiate fare before you get in.
STAY LENGTH	3 to 4 nights. 5 if combining with Atlas Mountains day trips.

DO

- + The souks in late afternoon. Get lost on purpose. Bargain hard.
- + Jemaa el-Fnaa at sunset, then dinner at one of the food stalls
- + Bahia Palace, Saadian Tombs, Madrasa Ben Youssef in one morning
- + Jardin Majorelle and YSL Museum (book online)
- + Hammam at Royal Mansour or La Mamounia for the splurge, or any small medina hammam for the real thing

SKIP

- The snake charmers and chained monkeys on Jemaa el-Fnaa (they will demand money)
- The "tannery tour" pitches from strangers (it is a sales setup)
- Going in August unless you are spending most of it by a pool
- Wearing anything revealing in the medina. Dress respectfully.

MY TAKE

The hotel choice in Marrakech matters more than almost anywhere else. A good riad makes the whole trip. A bad riad makes you want to leave on day two. Spend the money on the right roof terrace and the right courtyard. The medina outside will provide everything else.

ICELAND · NORTH ATLANTIC

Reykjavik

THE VOLCANIC CAPITAL. GEOTHERMAL POOLS, NORTHERN LIGHTS, EXPENSIVE COFFEE, BIG LANDSCAPES.

Reykjavik is the smallest capital city in the guide and the one with the biggest landscape outside it. The city is a base. The Blue Lagoon, the Golden Circle, the glaciers, the waterfalls, the northern lights are the real draw. The hotels are good. The food is very good. Everything else costs more than you expect.

The city is small enough that everywhere central is fine. Midborg (downtown) on the Laugavegur shopping street is the heart, walking distance to everything. The Old Harbour is the best spot for restaurants and whale-watching tours. The Hallgrímskirkja end of Laugavegur is quieter and uphill. Stay in Midborg. Use the airport bus, do day trips, sleep in the city.

WHERE TO STAY

PREMIUM

The Reykjavik *EDITION*

Old Harbour · waterfront, near Harpa Concert Hall

Ian Schrager's EDITION brand at full Reykjavik intensity. 253 rooms with views over the harbour and Mt. Esja, Michelin-starred chef in the restaurant, the warm Icelandic minimalism done at a high level. The benchmark luxury in the city.

From ~\$550 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Reykjavik+EDITION

MID · BOUTIQUE

ION City *Hotel*

Midborg · top of Laugavegur

Design-led boutique on Reykjavik's main shopping street. Icelandic birch, wool curtains, custom furniture, a great in-house restaurant (Sumac, Middle Eastern). The most considered design hotel in the city.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=ION+City+Hotel+Reykjavik

MID · BOUTIQUE

Sand *Hotel**Midborg · Laugavegur, walking distance to everything*

Sophisticated boutique on the main street with rooms built around Icelandic craft materials (sand, lava stone, driftwood) and a rooftop hot tub with Hallgrímskirkja views. Breakfast from Sandholt bakery downstairs is one of the best in town.

From ~\$300 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Sand+Hotel+Reykjavik

SMART VALUE

Hotel *Eyja* Guldsmeden*Midborg · just off Laugavegur*

Sixty-five-room Guldsmeden boutique with Balinese-wood four-posters, organic toiletries, and one of the best breakfasts in town. Calm, friendly, well-priced for what you get in Iceland. The smartest mid-budget pick.

From ~\$200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Eyja+Guldsmeden+Reykjavik

BACKPACKER

Kex *Hostel**Midborg · former biscuit factory on the seafront*

Design-led hostel in a former biscuit factory. Big restaurant, live music, harbourfront location. One of the best-known social hostels in Europe. Private rooms exist but it is mainly a dorm play.

From ~\$50 / night (dorm), ~\$140 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kex+Hostel+Reykjavik

BACKPACKER

Loft *HI Hostel**Midborg · Bankastræti, top of Laugavegur*

Hostel-hotel hybrid with a rooftop bar at the top of Laugavegur. Luxury dorms and chic private rooms. Best location of any budget bed in the city.

From ~\$55 / night (dorm), ~\$160 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Loft+HI+Hostel+Reykjavik

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>June to August</i> (midnight sun, mild) and <i>February to March</i> (best northern lights chances, snow).
WORST MONTHS	October and November (often wet, no aurora yet). April and May (in-between weather).
AIRPORT	Keflavik (KEF). 45 min to Reykjavik. Use the FlyBus or the Airport Direct shuttle.
GET AROUND	Walk the city. Rent a car for day trips outside (essential). Avoid driving in winter without 4WD.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 3 nights. 5 to 7 if doing the Ring Road or South Coast properly.

DO

- + Blue Lagoon on the way from or to the airport (book ahead)
- + Golden Circle day trip (Thingvellir, Geysir, Gullfoss in one day)
- + South Coast day trip (waterfalls, black sand beach, glacier views)
- + Hallgrímskirkja tower for the Reykjavik skyline view
- + Eat at Dill, Matur og Drykkur, or any of the lamb-soup places

SKIP

- The Blue Lagoon at midday in summer (book the early or late slot)
- Hákarl (fermented shark). Locals do not actually eat it.
- Hunting the northern lights without a tour or app (you will miss them)
- Doing the Ring Road in 3 days. It needs 7 minimum.

MY TAKE

*Reykjavik is not the destination. Reykjavik is the **basecamp**. Spend a night on either end of the trip, but the actual reason you came to Iceland is what is outside the city. Rent the car. Drive south.*

GREECE · CYCLADES

Mykonos

THE PARTY ISLAND. BEACH CLUBS, WHITE HOUSES, LATE NIGHTS, EXPENSIVE LUNCHES, NO SLEEP.

Mykonos is the noisiest, glossiest, most expensive Greek island, and it has been earning that reputation for forty years. Beach clubs that charge a hundred euros for a sun lounger, restaurants that charge more, nightlife that does not stop, and a postcard-perfect whitewashed town in the middle of it all. Love it or hate it, you should see it once.

Pick your zone. Mykonos Town (Chora) is the whitewashed centre, the windmills, Little Venice, the boutique shopping and the nightlife. Best for first-timers and walkable evenings. Psarou is the celebrity beach (Nammos, Astir) with the most expensive sunbeds in Greece. Platis Gialos and Ornos are family-friendly bays with most of the resort hotels and easy beach hopping. Paradise and Super Paradise are the party beaches. Stay in Town or Ornos for first trip.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Mykonos *Blu*

Psarou · hillside above Nammos beach

The Grecotel flagship and the most coveted address on the island. Hillside Cycladic villas above Psarou bay, three restaurants, the spa, several pools, the lot. Walking distance down to Nammos and the Psarou beach club scene. The classic Mykonos flex.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Mykonos+Blu+Grecotel

PREMIUM

Cali *Mykonos*

Kalafati · east coast, quieter side

New-generation luxury on the east coast away from the noise. Sea-facing rooms, almost all with private pool, one-mile clifftop infinity pool, dedicated beach club. The hotel for people who want the Mykonos hotel without the Mykonos circus.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Cali+Mykonos

PREMIUM

Bill & Co *Suites*

Megali Ammos · 5 min walk to Chora

Adults-only suites with private terraces facing the sunset over the Aegean. Famously photogenic infinity pool, Michelin-starred Beefbar on-site, walking distance to Town. The polished design pick.

From ~\$600 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Bill+and+Coo+Suites+Mykonos

MID

Branco *Mykonos**Platis Gialos · beachfront*

Chic five-star boutique right on Platis Gialos beach with a high-energy beach bar, great music, and easy water-taxi access to Paradise and Super Paradise. The right mid-budget pick if you want to stay where the daytime party is.

From ~\$380 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Branco+Mykonos

SMART VALUE

Petinos *Beach* Hotel*Platis Gialos · beachfront, family-friendly*

Reliable four-star on Platis Gialos beach with sea-view rooms, a good pool, breakfast on the sand. Not flashy. Best value option in the resort belt for people who want a real holiday rather than a photoshoot.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Petinos+Beach+Hotel+Mykonos

BACKPACKER

Paraga Beach *Hostel**Paraga · between Paradise and Platis Gialos*

The original Mykonos backpacker spot. Dorms and cheap private rooms walking distance to the beach, a buzzy on-site bar, and shuttles to Chora. The realistic cheap bed on Mykonos.

From ~\$45 / night (dorm), ~\$140 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Paraga+Beach+Hostel+Mykonos

BACKPACKER

Mykonos *Bedbox* Hostel*Mykonos Town · 15 min walk from centre*

Capsule-style design hostel a short walk from Chora. Private capsules, lockers, a pool, free breakfast. Best for solo travellers who want easy walking access to Mykonos Town nightlife.

From ~\$50 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Bedbox+Hostel+Mykonos

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>Late May to early July</i> and <i>September</i> . Hot, lively, manageable. Skip August unless that is the trip.
WORST MONTHS	November to April (most hotels closed). August (peak prices, peak crowds).
AIRPORT	Mykonos (JMK). 10 min to Town. Direct flights from most European hubs in summer.
GET AROUND	Taxis are limited and pricey. Rent an ATV or small car. Buses connect Town to the main beaches cheaply.
STAY LENGTH	3 to 5 nights is right. Pair with Santorini or Paros by ferry.

DO

- + Sunset cocktails in Little Venice, walking back through Chora
- + Lunch at Nammos or Scorpios, even if you split a salad to say you went
- + Day trip ferry to Delos (the archaeological site, not the bar)
- + Eat at Kiki's Tavern (no signage, no electricity, no menu, only good)
- + Beach hop by water taxi from Platis Gialos

SKIP

- August. You will not enjoy it and you will pay 3x.
- Renting a car you do not need in Chora (no parking, narrow lanes)
- Driving an ATV after drinks. People die every summer doing this.
- Restaurants right next to the windmills (tourist pricing, tourist food)

MY TAKE

*Mykonos is a **three-night party stop**, not a holiday. Go for the beach clubs, the food, the sunset in Chora. Then take the morning ferry to Santorini or Paros and slow down. Mykonos on day five is too much for anyone.*

GREECE · CYCLADES

Santorini

THE CALDERA. WHITE VILLAGES, BLUE DOMES, VOLCANO VIEWS, SUNSETS, HONEYMOONS.

Santorini is the most photographed island in Europe. The flooded volcano caldera, the white-cube villages clinging to the cliff edge, the famous sunsets, the blue-domed churches. It is also small, expensive, and overrun in summer. Done right, it is unforgettable. Done wrong, it is a queue.

Pick your village by view. Oia is the postcard at the northern tip: blue domes, the famous sunset, the most expensive hotels. Imerovigli sits at the highest point of the caldera rim and has the best panoramic views of the volcano. Fira is the capital with the most nightlife and the best transport. Firostefani is between Fira and Imerovigli, slightly cheaper. The beach towns (Kamari, Perissa, Akrotiri) are quieter and cheaper but lose the caldera view. First trip, stay in Oia or Imerovigli for the view.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Canaves Oia *Suites*

Oia · cliffside, the most photographed end

The defining luxury hotel in Oia. 24 cliff-carved suites, an elevator (rare here), two infinity pools, the sunset view directly from your terrace. The benchmark Santorini stay and the one most guests come back to.

From ~\$1,500 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Canaves+Oia+Suites

PREMIUM

Grace Hotel *Santorini*

Imerovigli · highest point of the caldera

Auberge Collection property at the highest point on the caldera rim, with the most dramatic infinity pool view on the island. Minimalist Cycladic design, suites with private plunge pools, panoramic views all the way to Oia. The most architectural luxury on Santorini.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Grace+Hotel+Santorini+Imerovigli

PREMIUM

Katikies *Santorini**Oia · cliffside, classic sunset side*

Twenty private houses carved into the Oia cliff with the iconic seamless infinity pool. The shot you have seen on Instagram a hundred times. Adult-only, romantic, full Oia luxury.

From ~\$1,100 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Katikies+Santorini+Oia

MID · BOUTIQUE

Astra *Suites**Imerovigli · centre of the village*

Family-run for over thirty years and still one of the warmest hotels on the caldera. Cycladic suites, heated infinity pool, sunset from every terrace. Personal service the bigger hotels cannot match. The best caldera-view hotel in this price tier.

From ~\$500 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Astra+Suites+Imerovigli

SMART VALUE

Strogili *Oia**Oia · caldera edge, off the main path*

Apartments at the edge of the Oia caldera with a perfect panorama of the village and the volcano. The pool is high enough that the view is even better than from the rooms. Breakfast on the terrace. The smartest fair-priced caldera-view stay in Oia.

From ~\$300 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Strogili+Oia+Santorini

BACKPACKER

Caveland *Santorini**Karterados · 10 min by bus to Fira*

Hostel inside a 17th-century cave winery, away from the caldera but full of character. Big pool, hammocks, communal dinners, well-run shuttles to Fira and the beaches. The best budget bed on Santorini.

From ~\$35 / night (dorm), ~\$110 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Caveland+Santorini+Hostel

BACKPACKER

Anema by the Sea *Guesthouse**Fira · 10 min walk to caldera*

Small guesthouse two streets back from the Fira caldera. No view, but clean private rooms with breakfast at hostel prices. The right pick if you want central Fira walkable access without paying the view premium.

From ~\$60 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Anema+by+the+Sea+Fira+Santorini](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Anema+by+the+Sea+Fira+Santorini)

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>Late April to June</i> and <i>September to October</i> . Warm, less crowded, manageable prices.
WORST MONTHS	November to March (many hotels closed). July and August (peak crowds, peak prices).
AIRPORT	Santorini (JTR). 20 min to Fira or 30 min to Oia. Most flights via Athens.
GET AROUND	Rental car or ATV for freedom. Buses link the main villages cheaply. Walking the caldera path from Fira to Oia takes 2 to 3 hours and is one of the best things to do.
STAY LENGTH	3 nights minimum. 4 is ideal. Anything more and you have run out of island.

DO

- + Walk the caldera path from Fira to Oia (start early, end at sunset in Oia)
- + Sunset in Oia, but find a spot 30 minutes before everyone else does
- + Wine tasting at Santo Wines or Venetsanos at sunset
- + Day trip catamaran cruise around the caldera (every hotel can book one)
- + Dinner at Selene, Metaxy Mas, or Pyrgos Bar Restaurant

SKIP

- Riding donkeys up the Fira cliff. It is cruel and the cable car is better.
- Booking a non-caldera-view room and being disappointed
- The Red and Black Beaches in August (overcrowded, hot, parking nightmare)
- Trying to do Santorini and Mykonos in 3 days total

MY TAKE

The view is the entire point of Santorini. If you cannot afford a caldera-view hotel, sleep cheaply in a beach town and just spend your evenings at sunset bars in Oia and Imerovigli. Do not pay top dollar for a room with no view. That is the worst of both worlds.

SPAIN · BALEARICS

Ibiza

THE WHITE ISLAND. BEACH CLUBS, SUPERCLUBS, WELLNESS RETREATS, SUNSET BARS, TWO COMPLETELY DIFFERENT ISLANDS IN ONE.

Ibiza is two islands at once. There is the party Ibiza: Pacha, Ushuaïa, Hi, the all-night clubs and the foam parties. And then there is the other Ibiza: the bohemian north, the pine forests, the cliff bays, the wellness retreats and the hippy markets. Most visitors only see one side. Both are worth the trip if you pick your hotel correctly.

Pick by what you want. Playa d'en Bossa is the party strip: Ushuaïa, Hi, Bora Bora, hotels for the club crowd. San Antonio is the budget-party west coast with the Café del Mar sunset scene. Ibiza Town and Talamanca are central, walkable, and have the best food. Santa Eulalia is the calm, family-friendly east coast. The wild north (San Joan, Cala Xarraca, Portinatx) is the bohemian-luxury side with Six Senses and the slow stays. First trip, decide which Ibiza you came for and base accordingly.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Six Senses *Ibiza*

Cala Xarraca · north tip, secluded bay

The wellness flagship on the bohemian north coast. 116 rooms including beach-cave suites and pool villas, holistic spa, organic restaurants, sunset cocktails at Beach Caves. The "other Ibiza" at full intensity. Worth the drive from the airport.

From ~\$1,200 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Six+Senses+Ibiza](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Six+Senses+Ibiza)

PREMIUM

Nobu Hotel *Ibiza Bay*

Talamanca · beachfront, 10 min from Ibiza Town

Nobu hotel in a Robert De Niro pocket of Talamanca bay. Iconic beachfront pool, the Nobu restaurant on site, walking distance to a quiet bay with views over to Ibiza Town. The premium pick that balances calm with proximity to the action.

From ~\$650 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nobu+Hotel+Ibiza+Bay](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nobu+Hotel+Ibiza+Bay)

MID · BOUTIQUE

Montesol *Experimental**Ibiza Town · Vara de Rey, walking distance to old town*

The Experimental Group's rework of Ibiza's oldest hotel. Quiet, elegant, design-led, with one of the best cocktail bars on the island. The town stay if you want to wake up walking distance from Dalt Vila and have dinner in actual Ibiza, not in a club.

From ~\$350 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Montesol+Experimental+Ibiza

SMART VALUE

Hotel *Riomar* Ibiza*Santa Eulalia · beachfront, quiet east coast*

Bohemian-style Tribute Portfolio hotel on the Santa Eulalia promenade. Direct beach access, big pool, walking distance to the town's restaurants. The smartest fair-priced stay on the calmer east coast.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Riomar+Ibiza

BACKPACKER

The Giri *Residence**San Joan · north, near Benirràs Beach*

Small boutique guesthouse in San Joan village in the bohemian north. Whitewashed rooms, big garden, the wellness-Ibiza vibe without the Six Senses price. The right pick if you want quiet north-Ibiza energy on a real budget.

From ~\$120 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Giri+Residence+San+Joan+Ibiza

BACKPACKER

Hostal La *Torre**Cap Negret · cliff-edge, near San Antonio*

Small clifftop hotel famous for its sunset terrace where DJ-led sunsets have been a fixture since the 1990s. Simple rooms, killer view, walkable to the bus to San Antonio. The cheapest way to have a memorable Ibiza sunset every night.

From ~\$130 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hostal+La+Torre+Ibiza

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>Late May, June, September.</i> Beach clubs open, weather perfect, before or after peak. Avoid August for prices.
WORST MONTHS	November to April (most clubs and beach clubs shut). August (peak prices).
AIRPORT	Ibiza (IBZ). 15 to 45 min to anywhere on the island.
GET AROUND	Rent a car. The island is bigger than people think and the bus network is limited. Taxis are scarce and overpriced in summer.
STAY LENGTH	4 to 7 nights. Pair with Formentera by ferry for 1 to 2 nights of slow.

DO

- + Sunset at Café del Mar, Café Mambo, or Hostal La Torre
- + A boat day to Formentera (clearest water in the Mediterranean)
- + Cala Comte, Cala Salada, or Aguas Blancas for the best beaches
- + One club night at Hi, Ushuaïa, or Pacha for the full experience
- + Hippy market at Las Dalias on Saturdays, Punta Arabí on Wednesdays

SKIP

- San Antonio West End strip unless you are 19 and looking for that
- Booking accommodation more than 20 minutes from where you actually want to be
- Drinking 18 euro Coronas at beach clubs (BYO water, eat before)
- Buying club tickets at the door. Book online for half the price.

MY TAKE

*The Ibiza most people miss is the **north of the island**. Pine forests, secret coves, the bohemian-luxury hotels, the long lunches at Aubergine and Cas Costas. If you have already done party Ibiza, give the north a week. It is a different country.*

SPAIN · BALEARICS

Mallorca

THE BIG ONE. PALMA, MOUNTAIN VILLAGES, CLIFF BAYS, CYCLING, HIKING, FINCA HOTELS.

Mallorca is the biggest of the Balearic islands and the most varied. Palma is a real city with a Gothic cathedral and a serious restaurant scene. The Tramuntana mountains in the northwest are UNESCO-listed and one of the best hiking and cycling regions in Europe. The east coast has the cliff bays. The south has the resorts. You can have five different holidays here.

Pick your zone. Palma is the city base: walkable, great food, good design hotels. Deià and Sóller in the Tramuntana are the chic mountain villages: stone houses, olive groves, the celebrity-quiet luxury. The east coast (Artà, Cala Ratjada) and south coast (Es Trenc, Colònia de Sant Jordi) are quieter beach country. The Pollença area in the north is good for cycling and family. First trip, base in Palma for two nights, then Deià for two.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Cap *Rocat*

Cala Blava · 19th-century fortress, 15 min from Palma

A 19th-century clifftop fortress converted into 24 suites. Drawbridges, bunkers, a private rocky beach, an infinity pool on the cliff edge. Adults-only, dramatic, completely original. The most extraordinary hotel in the Balearics and the one most guests remember as the best they have ever stayed in.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Cap+Rocat+Mallorca

PREMIUM

Belmond La *Residencia*

Deià · Tramuntana mountains

A 16th-century manor house in the most romantic village in Mallorca. Two pools, tennis courts, an award-winning restaurant, and the kind of celebrity-clientele history that makes a hotel quietly legendary. The most romantic stay on the island.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Belmond+La+Residencia+Deia

MID · BOUTIQUE

Hotel *Cort**Palma · Plaça de Cort, old town*

Sixteen-room boutique right on Palma's beautiful main square, opposite the city hall. Stylish, walkable to the cathedral and the best food streets, with a great rooftop bar. The smartest design pick for a city base.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Cort+Palma+Mallorca

SMART VALUE

Hotel *Mamá**Palma · Plaça Cort area*

Quietly excellent four-star in central Palma. Spa, rooftop pool, walking distance to the cathedral and to the food scene around Santa Catalina. Punches above its price.

From ~\$200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Mama+Palma

BACKPACKER

Hostal *Cuba**Palma · Santa Catalina district*

Cuban-themed boutique-budget hotel above the famous Cuba bar. Bright rooms, fair prices, in the middle of Santa Catalina, which is Palma's best food and drink street. Great budget pick for the city.

From ~\$110 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hostal+Cuba+Palma+Mallorca

BACKPACKER

Urban Hostel *Palma**Palma · 10 min walk from old town*

Reliable mid-budget hostel in central Palma. Clean private rooms and dorms, a kitchen, friendly staff. The cheapest decent bed in central Palma. The right pick for solo travellers using Palma as a base.

From ~\$35 / night (dorm), ~\$80 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Urban+Hostel+Palma+Mallorca

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May to June</i> and <i>September to October</i> . Warm, fewer crowds, hiking and beach both work.
WORST MONTHS	July and August (peak crowds, peak prices, brutal heat inland). November to March (cooler, many resorts close).
AIRPORT	Palma (PMI). 15 min to Palma, 45 to 90 min to the rest of the island.
GET AROUND	Rent a car. Mallorca is too big for buses alone. Palma itself is walkable.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. 7 to 10 nights is ideal for splitting Palma and Tramuntana.

DO

- + Palma Cathedral and the Old Town in one morning, food markets after
- + Drive the Sa Calobra road through the Tramuntana (the road is the attraction)
- + Deià village, lunch at Ca's Patró March on the cove
- + The Sóller train (vintage wooden train, 1912, real, beautiful)
- + Cap de Formentor at sunset (drive carefully, the road is narrow)

SKIP

- Magaluf unless you are 19 and from the UK
- Es Trenc beach on a hot August Saturday (parking is a war)
- Renting a car in Palma if you are only staying in the city
- Trying to "do" all of Mallorca in 3 days. Pick two zones.

MY TAKE

Mallorca is the most underrated mid-size island in Europe. Most people think of Magaluf or cruise day trips. The real Mallorca is the mountain villages, the cycling, the food in Palma, the secret coves on the east coast. Treat it like Tuscany with a beach and you will get it right.

ITALY · MEDITERRANEAN

Sicily

THE LARGEST ISLAND. MOUNT ETNA, BAROQUE TOWNS, BEACHES, PASTA, RUINS, THREE THOUSAND YEARS OF EMPIRES.

Sicily is the largest island in the Mediterranean and one of the most layered cultures in Europe. Greek temples, Roman amphitheatres, Byzantine mosaics, Norman cathedrals, Arab pastries, Spanish baroque, a still-active volcano, and the best pasta in Italy. A week barely covers it. Two weeks is closer to right.

Pick your base. Taormina on the east coast is the famous one: cliff town, White Lotus filming location, Mount Etna views. The southeast (Ortigia island in Syracuse, Noto, Ragusa) is the baroque-town zone. Palermo on the northwest is the gritty, food-driven capital with the markets and the mosaics. The west coast (Trapani, Marsala) is quieter and cheaper. Most first trips combine Taormina for views with the southeast for towns, or split between Palermo and Taormina.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

San Domenico Palace, *Four Seasons*

Taormina · 14th-century convent, cliff-top

A 14th-century Dominican convent turned Four Seasons. Cliffside gardens overlooking the Ionian Sea, Mount Etna in the distance, the hotel from the second season of *The White Lotus*. The most famous luxury hotel in Sicily and absolutely earning it.

From ~\$1,800 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=San+Domenico+Palace+Taormina](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=San+Domenico+Palace+Taormina)

PREMIUM

Verdura *Resort*

Sciacca · south coast, 230 hectares

Rocco Forte's vast south-coast resort. Three golf courses, six pools, a 60-metre infinity pool, a private beach. Genuinely one of the great Mediterranean resorts. The right pick if you want a real holiday rather than a sightseeing trip.

From ~\$700 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Verdura+Resort+Sicily](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Verdura+Resort+Sicily)

MID · BOUTIQUE

Ortea Palace *Sicily**Ortigia · former post office, Syracuse*

Marriott Autograph Collection inside a restored 1920s post-office palace on Ortigia island. Marble bathrooms, rooftop bar, walking distance to the Duomo square and the Ortigia market. The best base for exploring baroque Sicily.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Ortea+Palace+Sicily+Ortigia

SMART VALUE

Hotel Villa *Belvedere**Taormina · 5 min walk to centre*

Family-run since 1902, the most quietly excellent mid-range hotel in Taormina. Gardens, a small but beautiful pool with Etna views, breakfast on the terrace. The smartest fair-priced stay in the famous town. Far better than its star count suggests.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Hotel+Villa+Belvedere+Taormina

BACKPACKER

A Casa di *Amici**Palermo · Vucciria market area, walking distance to old town*

Funky family-run guesthouse-hostel in the centre of Palermo's old town near the Vucciria market. Private rooms and dorms in a colourful 19th-century palazzo. Walking distance to the cathedral, the markets, and Ballarò. The best budget bed in Palermo.

From ~\$30 / night (dorm), ~\$70 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=A+Casa+di+Amici+Palermo

BACKPACKER

Ostello degli *Elefanti**Catania · centre of old town*

Design-led hostel in central Catania. Private rooms and dorms, a great rooftop bar with Etna views on clear days, walking distance to the fish market and the duomo. Best cheap bed on the east coast.

From ~\$25 / night (dorm), ~\$70 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Ostello+degli+Elefanti+Catania

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May, June, September, October.</i> Hot but manageable, swimming still good in September, fewer crowds.
WORST MONTHS	August (sirocco wind, 40C inland, peak crowds). January and February (cool, plenty closed).
AIRPORT	Catania (CTA) for the east. Palermo (PMO) for the west. Both work for first trips.
GET AROUND	Rent a car. Sicily is too big and the train network too slow. Palermo and Catania you walk; everywhere else you drive.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 5 nights. 7 to 10 is ideal for an east-coast or west-coast loop. Two weeks for the whole island.

DO

- + Mount Etna day trip (cable car up, hike around the craters, vineyard lunch on the way down)
- + Ortigia island in Syracuse: the duomo, the morning market, dinner on the seafront
- + Valley of the Temples in Agrigento (book sunset slot if you can)
- + Palermo street food tour: arancini, sfincione, panelle, pane con la milza
- + Taormina Greek Theatre, ideally for an evening concert in summer

SKIP

- Doing Sicily in less than 5 days. You will see almost nothing.
- Mainland-Italy-style tipping. It is not the custom here.
- Driving into the historic centres. Park outside, walk in.
- August in Palermo unless you genuinely want to feel what 42C is like

MY TAKE

*Sicily is the **most underrated country in Europe**. It is not Italy, exactly. It is its own thing. Better food than most of mainland Italy. More history than almost anywhere on earth. Go before everyone else figures it out. Which they will, in the next five years.*

USA · EAST COAST

New York

THE CAPITAL OF CAPITALS. SKYSCRAPERS, SUBWAYS, SLICES, GALLERIES, TWENTY-FOUR-HOUR EVERYTHING.

New York is the only city in this guide where the city itself is the destination. No beaches, no mountains, no ruins. Just eight million people stacked twenty stories high, the densest restaurant scene in the world, the best museums in North America, and an energy that does not exist anywhere else. You either love it on day one or you never will.

Pick your neighborhood. SoHo is the cobblestone-and-cast-iron heart of downtown: walkable to TriBeCa, the West Village, Nolita, Lower East Side, with the best boutique hotels in the city. West Village is the prettiest, most photogenic residential pocket. Lower East Side and East Village are the late-night creative neighborhoods. NoMad and Midtown are the central tourist zones. Brooklyn (Williamsburg, Brooklyn Heights) is for second trips or longer stays. First trip, stay in SoHo or the West Village.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

The *Mercer* Hotel

SoHo · cast-iron landmark, corner of Mercer and Prince

The original downtown luxury boutique and still the celebrity-favourite address in SoHo. Loft-style rooms in a red-brick Romanesque landmark, the underground Mercer Kitchen by Jean-Georges, and the most discreet service south of Midtown. The downtown New York stay.

From ~\$800 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Mercer+Hotel+SoHo+New+York

PREMIUM

The Ned *NoMad*

NoMad · Madison Square Park, 28th Street

Soho House group's New York Ned. Beaux-Arts building, Ned's Club downstairs, theatrical Schrager-style interiors, members-only spaces guests get to access. The hotel for people who want both Midtown convenience and downtown energy.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Ned+NoMad+New+York

MID · BOUTIQUE

Arlo *SoHo**SoHo · west edge, near Hudson Square*

Smart compact-room boutique with festoon-lit courtyard, the Foxtail jazz bar, and a great rooftop in summer. Rooms are small (this is New York) but the price-to-location ratio is one of the best downtown. Punches above its tier.

From ~\$320 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Arlo+SoHo+New+York

MID · BOUTIQUE

The *Manner**SoHo · tree-lined street, 97 rooms*

New SoHo boutique with a service philosophy that feels personal. First-name basis with staff, low-tech in the public spaces, a rooftop with a view, no check-out (bill arrives by email). Smart, calm, deliberately unflashy.

From ~\$450 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Manner+SoHo+New+York

SMART VALUE

Moxy NYC *Downtown**Lower East Side · steps from SoHo and East Village*

Compact, smartly designed rooms at the crossroads of SoHo and the Lower East Side, with The Highlight Room rooftop bar on top. The cheapest stylish room in downtown Manhattan that does not feel cheap.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Moxy+NYC+Downtown

BACKPACKER

Freehand *New York**Flatiron · Lexington Avenue, near Gramercy Park*

Hostel-hotel hybrid with private rooms and the famous Bar Studio Manhattan and Broken Shaker cocktail bars on site. Central, well-designed, social. Best mid-budget bed in Manhattan with actual neighbourhood credibility.

From ~\$70 / night (shared), ~\$200 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Freehand+New+York

BACKPACKER

Pod 51

Midtown East · between Grand Central and Times Square

Compact "pod" rooms in central Midtown. Tiny but clean, with a rooftop terrace. The cheapest decent private room in Midtown Manhattan. Best budget pick if you need to be near Grand Central or Penn Station.

From ~\$130 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pod+51+New+York

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>May, June, September, October.</i> Walkable temperatures, parks at their best, the city alive without melting.
WORST MONTHS	July and August (humid, swampy, locals leave). January and February (brutal cold, slush).
AIRPORT	JFK and Newark for international, LaGuardia for domestic. Use AirTrain plus subway, or a yellow cab. Not Uber from the airport (surge pricing kills you).
GET AROUND	Subway is the answer to almost everything. Walk in Manhattan south of 14th Street. Yellow cabs for late nights.
STAY LENGTH	Minimum 4 nights. 5 to 7 is the sweet spot.

DO

- + The Met, MoMA, the Whitney. Pick two, give each a half day.
- + A Broadway show. Book online ahead or use TodayTix for day-of deals.
- + Walk the High Line south from Hudson Yards to the Whitney
- + A bagel breakfast (Russ & Daughters), a slice at lunch (Joe's, Prince Street), dinner anywhere in the West Village
- + Brooklyn Bridge at sunset, walking from Brooklyn back to Manhattan

SKIP

- Times Square unless you have a Broadway ticket. Walk through fast.
- Restaurants on main tourist drags (Times Square, near the Empire State, Little Italy proper)
- Empire State Building observation deck. Top of the Rock or Edge are better.
- Renting a car. You will hate yourself.

MY TAKE

*New York rewards **walking the same neighbourhood in depth** over racing across the city. Pick a base, walk twenty blocks in every direction from it over five days. You will see more of actual New York than people who Uber to twelve attractions and remember none of them.*

USA · FLORIDA

Miami

THE CARIBBEAN US. BEACH, ART DECO, CUBAN FOOD, NIGHTLIFE, NEON, MONEY.

Miami is the closest you can get to Latin America without leaving the United States. Cuban Spanish on the streets, the best Caribbean restaurants in North America, Art Deco architecture along the beach, and a nightlife scene that runs from sunset to sunrise. The beach is one thing. The neighbourhoods inland are the other.

Pick your zone. South Beach is the famous strip: Ocean Drive, Art Deco, the beach clubs, the loud nightlife. Mid-Beach is calmer and more sophisticated (Faena, Soho House). Brickell is the urban-skyline downtown with the best restaurants and a more grown-up energy. Wynwood is the converted warehouse district with the murals and the art galleries. Coconut Grove is family-quiet and leafy. First trip, split between South Beach and one of Brickell or Wynwood.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

The *Setai* Miami Beach

South Beach · Collins Avenue at 20th Street, oceanfront

A restored 1936 Art Deco landmark with Asian-inspired interiors. Three temperature-controlled infinity pools, private beach, the kind of understated luxury that feels like a sanctuary in the middle of South Beach. Ranked among the top 15 hotels in the US in 2026. The benchmark Miami stay.

From ~\$900 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=The+Setai+Miami+Beach

PREMIUM

Four Seasons at The *Surf Club*

Surfside · north of Mid-Beach, beachfront

The Surf Club is the 1930s private club where Sinatra and Churchill stayed, now a Four Seasons. Richard Meier architecture, Le Sirenuse outpost from Positano, four pools, the most refined beach stay in Miami. Also a US News top hotel.

From ~\$1,200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Four+Seasons+Surf+Club+Miami

PREMIUM

1 Hotel *South Beach**South Beach · oceanfront, Collins Avenue at 24th*

Reclaimed wood, indoor plants everywhere, organic cotton linens, four pools including a rooftop. The biophilic-design hotel that started the wellness-luxury trend in Miami. Sustainability-led without losing the South Beach setting.

From ~\$700 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=1+Hotel+South+Beach+Miami

MID · BOUTIQUE

Faena *Hotel* Miami Beach*Mid-Beach · Collins between 32nd and 36th*

Alan Faena's theatrical art-driven hotel. Damien Hirst's gold-leafed woolly mammoth skeleton in the lobby. Faena Theater with cabaret performances. Francis Mallmann wood-fire restaurant. Red-and-white opulent rooms. Unlike any other Miami hotel.

From ~\$550 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Faena+Hotel+Miami+Beach

SMART VALUE

Kimpton *EPIC* Miami*Brickell · downtown, Biscayne Bay views*

Two-tower urban hotel on the Miami River with a rooftop pool overlooking the bay. Walking distance to Brickell's restaurants, ten minutes by car to South Beach. The smartest fair-priced Miami stay if you do not need the beach right outside your door.

From ~\$280 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Kimpton+EPIC+Miami

BACKPACKER

Moxy Miami *Wynwood**Wynwood · centre of the mural district*

Compact, design-forward rooms in the heart of Wynwood. The lobby is the bar, the rooftop is the social space, the murals on the walls outside are the attraction. Best budget pick if you want to be in the cool neighbourhood, not on the beach.

From ~\$160 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Moxy+Miami+Wynwood

BACKPACKER

Generator *Miami Beach*

South Beach · 2 blocks from the beach, Collins Avenue

Design hostel in South Beach with private rooms and dorms, a pool, a rooftop bar. Walking distance to the Art Deco district and the beach. The only legitimate budget option in South Beach itself.

From ~\$55 / night (dorm), ~\$150 (private)

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Generator+Miami+Beach](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Generator+Miami+Beach)

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>November to April.</i> Dry, warm, the high season for a reason.
WORST MONTHS	June to October (hurricane season, humid, frequent storms). August is the worst.
AIRPORT	Miami International (MIA). 20 to 30 min to most of Miami. Use Uber or rental car; no good public transport from the airport.
GET AROUND	Rent a car or use Uber. Miami is spread out. South Beach itself is walkable. Watch the resort fees and the parking fees, they are real money.
STAY LENGTH	3 to 5 nights. 7 if combining with Keys or Everglades day trips.

DO

- + Cuban breakfast at Versailles in Little Havana, walk Calle Ocho after
- + Wynwood Walls and the galleries around it on a Saturday afternoon
- + Art Deco walking tour of South Beach, then sunset on the beach
- + Dinner at Joe's Stone Crab, KYU, or anywhere in Brickell or Wynwood
- + Day trip to the Everglades for airboats and alligators

SKIP

- Ocean Drive restaurants (touts on the sidewalk, tourist menus, bad food)
- Bayside Marketplace (cruise-ship mall)
- August unless you have a flight you cannot move
- Renting a car if you are only staying in South Beach (parking is a nightmare)

MY TAKE

*The real Miami is not Ocean Drive. The real Miami is **Little Havana for breakfast, Wynwood for the afternoon, Brickell for dinner.** Use the beach as a base, not as the whole trip. Split your nights between South Beach and the mainland and you will leave with a much better impression.*

MEXICO · YUCATAN

Tulum

THE JUNGLE COAST. CENOTES, MAYAN RUINS, BEACH CLUBS, TREEHOUSE HOTELS, MOSQUITOS, NO UBER.

Tulum was a quiet hippy beach village fifteen years ago. Now it is the most photographed stretch of jungle-and-beach in the Americas, with a hotel scene unlike anywhere else: treehouse suites built without right angles, hotels run by DJs, retreat centres run by shamans, and a price tier that has overtaken Bali Uluwatu. It still works if you understand what you are buying.

Pick your zone, and understand the price cliff. The Beach Zone (Zona Hotelera) is the Tulum you have seen on Instagram. Jungle-backed beach, the famous boutique hotels, \$200 to \$800 a night. Tulum Town (Pueblo) is the actual town, 4km inland, where rooms run \$40 to \$130. There is no Uber. Taxis cost \$7 to \$10 each way between town and beach, or you bike on the dedicated bike path. First trip, split nights between the two if budget matters. Pure beach zone if it does not.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Azulik Tulum

Beach Zone · jungle-and-treehouse, no children

The treehouse property that defined Tulum on Instagram. 48 hand-built wooden villas with no straight lines, no glass, no air conditioning, no TVs, no children. The SFER IK museum on-site, multiple restaurants, the Kin Toh treetop restaurant. Architecturally unlike anything else on earth.

From ~\$600 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Azulik+Tulum](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Azulik+Tulum)

PREMIUM

Nomade Tulum

Beach Zone · south end, beachfront

Wellness-and-music hotel that runs as a beach club, performance space, and retreat in one. Live music, cacao ceremonies, yoga, beach bungalows and jungle tents. The Tulum scene at full intensity. The hotel where everyone you meet ends up at sunset.

From ~\$500 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nomade+Tulum](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Nomade+Tulum)

PREMIUM

Habitas *Tulum**Beach Zone · south end, the quieter stretch*

Design-driven eco-luxury with community programming, wellness, and social dining. Clean lines, natural materials, private jungle-view terraces. One of the better-maintained sections of beach for sargassum management. The pick if you want Tulum without the noise.

From ~\$450 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Habitas+Tulum

MID · BOUTIQUE

Casa *Malca**Beach Zone · south end, near Sian Ka'an*

The most surreal hotel on the strip. A former Pablo Escobar mansion turned into an art-filled boutique hotel by gallerist Lio Malca. Pieces by Banksy, Basquiat, KAWS on the walls. Beach access through a tunnel under the property. Genuinely one of a kind.

From ~\$300 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casa+Malca+Tulum

SMART VALUE

Coco Tulum *Beach Hotel**Beach Zone · north end, beachfront*

The original whitewashed-cabana Tulum hotel. Bohemian cabanas right on the beach, swing-seat bar in the sand, beach club open all day. The most affordable real beachfront stay in the beach zone. Pure Tulum atmosphere at a sane price.

From ~\$200 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Coco+Tulum+Beach+Hotel

BACKPACKER

Pal Mar *Tulum**Beach Zone · centre, across from the beach*

Repurposed shipping-container rooms in the middle of the Tulum beach road, opposite the beach. Free parking (rare here), air conditioning, the best Instagram-spot location on the strip. The cheapest decent room actually in the beach zone.

From ~\$130 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Pal+Mar+Tulum

BACKPACKER

Tiki Tiki *Tulum**Tulum Town · near Holistika, 4km from beach*

Mid-century-modern budget boutique with a jungle-pool area, hammocks in every room, next to a vegan restaurant and a yoga studio. The aesthetic of beach-zone Tulum at town-Tulum prices. Best budget pick if you can deal with the bike or taxi to the beach.

From ~\$70 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Tiki+Tiki+Tulum

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>November to April.</i> Dry, warm, less sargassum. Peak season but worth it.
WORST MONTHS	May to October (sargassum peaks May to August, hurricane risk September to October).
AIRPORT	Cancun (CUN) 1.5 hours away, or new Tulum (TQO) 30 min away. Use private transfer; ADO bus is cheap but slow.
GET AROUND	No Uber. Bike between town and beach (4km, flat). Taxis are union-controlled and expensive but unavoidable for night.
STAY LENGTH	3 to 5 nights. Pair with a Yucatan road trip to Valladolid and Mérida for a full week.

DO

- + The Tulum ruins (the only Mayan ruins on the coast) at opening time
- + Cenote day: Gran Cenote, Cenote Calavera, Cenote Dos Ojos in one morning
- + Lunch at Hartwood or dinner at Arca (book weeks ahead)
- + Sunset at Papaya Playa Project or Mia Beach Club
- + Day trip to Sian Ka'an biosphere reserve (mangroves, lagoon tour, very quiet)

SKIP

- Renting a car you cannot park (no parking at most beach-zone hotels)
- Drinking tap water anywhere. Bottled or filtered only.
- The beach in peak sargassum months unless you accept the seaweed
- Drugs from strangers on the strip. Local police are very active.

MY TAKE

*Tulum is the most **over-priced relative to its actual experience** of any destination on this list. The hotels are extraordinary, the food is great, the cenotes are unique. But you pay Bali Uluwatu prices for the beach-zone version. Mix two nights in the beach zone with two in town and you get the Tulum experience for half the cost.*

COLOMBIA · CARIBBEAN COAST

Cartagena

THE WALLED CITY. COLONIAL SQUARES, BALCONIES IN FLOWERS, SALSA, CEVICHE, THE MOST PHOTOGENIC OLD TOWN IN THE AMERICAS.

Cartagena is the prettiest Spanish-colonial city in the Americas and the most underrated destination in this whole guide. UNESCO-listed walled old town, four-hundred-year-old churches and convents converted into boutique hotels, evening salsa in the squares, the best ceviche on the Caribbean coast. Three or four nights here changes how people think of Latin America.

Pick your neighborhood. The Walled City (Centro and San Diego) is the historic core: cobblestones, colonial mansions, the highest concentration of restaurants and boutique hotels. Getsemaní just outside the walls is the trendier, edgier neighbourhood with street art, cheaper boutique hotels, and the best nightlife. Bocagrande on the peninsula has the modern beachfront high-rises if you must be by the water. Stay in the Walled City or Getsemaní. Skip Bocagrande unless you specifically want the beach hotel.

WHERE TO STAY

ICONIC

Casa San Agustín

Walled City · Centro, three connected 17th-century mansions

Three former colonial mansions joined into a 30-room boutique. Leading Hotels of the World member, the most awarded service in Colombia, and the Alma restaurant on site. Consistently ranked the best hotel in the country.

From ~\$650 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casa+San+Agustin+Cartagena](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casa+San+Agustin+Cartagena)

PREMIUM

Sofitel Legend Santa Clara

Walled City · San Diego plaza, 1621 convent

The most beautiful hotel in Cartagena. A 1621 former Poor Clares convent turned into a sprawling Sofitel Legend. The largest courtyard pool in the city centre, surrounded by tropical greenery, two restaurants, a fantastic spa. Pure colonial drama at full luxury level.

From ~\$500 / night

[booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Sofitel+Legend+Santa+Clara+Cartagena](https://www.booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Sofitel+Legend+Santa+Clara+Cartagena)

MID · BOUTIQUE

Casa *Pestagua* Relais & Châteaux*Walled City · former mansion of the Count of Pestagua*

An 11-suite hotel inside the former colonial mansion of a Spanish count. Antique-style beds, an interior courtyard pool, a private beach club guests can use. Small, intimate, deeply romantic. The most personal of the high-end Cartagena options.

From ~\$400 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casa+Pestagua+Cartagena

SMART VALUE

Casona del *Colegio**Walled City · centre of Centro, walkable to everything*

Beautiful colonial boutique a notch below the headline luxury hotels but at significantly more accessible prices. Suites with private-balcony jacuzzis cost roughly the same as standard rooms at the Sofitel. Excellent service, great restaurant. The smartest value pick in the Walled City.

From ~\$220 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casona+del+Colegio+Cartagena

BACKPACKER

Hotel Casa India *Catalina**Walled City · Centro, near the main plaza*

Charming small hotel inside a colonial building in the heart of the Walled City. Personality, character, real Cartagena atmosphere at prices a fraction of the high-end neighbours. Best budget pick that still keeps you inside the walls.

From ~\$90 / night

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casa+India+Catalina+Cartagena

BACKPACKER

Casa Movida *Hostal**Getsemaní · the trendy neighbourhood outside the walls*

Stylish design hostel in Getsemaní with private rooms and dorms, a great breakfast, and the location to walk into the Walled City in five minutes or into Plaza Trinidad's evening salsa scene in two. Best social budget bed in Cartagena.

From ~\$25 / night (dorm), ~\$70 (private)

booking.com/searchresults.html?ss=Casa+Movida+Hostal+Cartagena

QUICK FACTS

BEST MONTHS	<i>December to April.</i> Dry, warm, less humid. The high season.
WORST MONTHS	September to November (rainy season, humid). August is peak heat.
AIRPORT	Rafael Núñez (CTG). 15 min to the Walled City. Use a hotel transfer or licensed taxi.
GET AROUND	Walk the Walled City and Getsemaní. Cabs for everywhere else (cheap, always negotiate fare first).
STAY LENGTH	3 to 5 nights. Pair with 2 nights in the Rosario Islands for the beach.

DO

- + Walk the walls at sunset, drink at Café del Mar, dinner after in Centro
- + Castillo de San Felipe (the hilltop fortress) in early morning
- + Eat ceviche at La Cevichería, dinner at Carmen or Celele
- + Day trip by boat to the Rosario Islands or Barú for beach time
- + Salsa night at Café Havana in Getsemaní (Friday or Saturday)

SKIP

- Bocagrande beaches (urban, mediocre, skip for the islands)
- Restaurants right on Plaza Santo Domingo (tourist pricing for average food)
- Buying emeralds from street vendors. Use a licensed shop with certificates.
- Walking outside the walls late at night alone in unfamiliar areas

MY TAKE

*Cartagena is the **most underrated city in this whole guide**. It is what people imagined Havana would be. Better hotels, better food, no embargo. Three or four nights here, plus two in the Rosario Islands, is one of the best short trips you can take in the Americas. Go before it changes.*

LOGISTICS · PART ONE

Flights.

THE BOOKING FRAMEWORK. WHAT I USE, WHEN TO BOOK, WHAT TO ACTUALLY PAY.

Flights are the single most variable cost in travel. Same seat, same plane, same date, three different prices depending on when and where you book. Most people overpay because they trust one search engine and book the first reasonable number they see. This is the workflow I use.

This section is short on purpose. The flight booking world has roughly 20 websites that all claim to be the cheapest. The truth is that four of them matter, in a specific order. The rest is timing rules and knowing when not to book.

MY STACK

How I *actually* book.

FOUR SITES. IN THIS ORDER. EVERY TIME.

There are dozens of flight search sites. I use four. Each one does a different job, and the order matters. Start at the top, work down. If a flight is going to be cheap, this workflow will find it. If it is going to be expensive, this workflow will at least make sure you are not paying more than you have to.

STEP 01 · SEARCH

Google *Flights*

The best price-discovery tool. Free.

Always start here. Google Flights has the cleanest interface, the most accurate date-grid view, and the price-history graph. Use the "Explore" map to see prices across a region when you do not have a fixed destination. Use the calendar view to see the cheapest day to fly within a month. Do not book here. Use it to find the price you should be paying.

STEP 02 · CROSS-CHECK

Skyscanner

Catches what Google misses, especially in Asia.

Skyscanner picks up budget airlines and regional carriers that Google Flights does not always show. Particularly useful in Southeast Asia where AirAsia, VietJet, and Cebu Pacific are sometimes cheaper. Use the "Everywhere" search if you are flexible on destination. Cross-check the price you found in Google Flights and see if Skyscanner shows a lower one.

STEP 03 · CROSS-CHECK AGAIN

Trip.com

Often cheaper for Asian routes and Asian airlines.

Trip.com is the international face of the Chinese travel giant Ctrip. It frequently has lower prices on Asian carriers (Cathay, ANA, JAL, Singapore Airlines, China Eastern) than the airline's own site. Their app is good. Their customer service is fine if you book ahead and do not need last-minute changes. Worth checking on every Asia route.

STEP 04 · BOOK

Booking.com (or direct with the airline)

Where I actually book. For the Genius discount.

Once I know the real price from steps 1 to 3, I book through Booking.com because their Genius programme gives me a discount on flights that often makes them the cheapest option anyway, and because all my hotels and flights end up in one place. If Booking.com cannot match the price, book direct with the airline. Never book through an unknown OTA you have not used before. The savings are not worth the support nightmare if anything goes wrong.

THE STACK · THREE RULES

- Always run all three search engines before booking. *Always*. The price gap between them can be 15-30% on the same flight.
- Search in incognito mode. Airlines and OTAs track your searches and bump prices on repeat visits.
- If business class is in budget, book direct with the airline. Better seat selection, easier changes, real upgrade chances at check-in.

WORTH KNOWING

The other *tools*.

NOT MY STACK. BUT WORTH KNOWING THEY EXIST.

I do not use these myself. I travel mainly around Asia and to Europe once or twice a year, and my workflow above gets the job done. But for people who fly more, or whose route patterns make these worth it, here is what you should know.

Error fare and deal alert services

These are subscription services that email you when an airline accidentally publishes the wrong price (a \$4,000 business-class fare priced at \$400) or when a sale drops below a threshold for your home city. The catch: deals are not for fixed destinations. You have to be flexible on where and when you fly. Worth subscribing if you fly often from one home airport.

The main ones: **Going** (formerly Scott's Cheap Flights, US-focused, by far the best-known), **Jack's Flight Club** (UK and Europe), **Secret Flying** (global, free, less curated), **Holiday Pirates** (Europe). Free tiers exist. Paid tiers (\$50 to \$100 per year) get you the better deals earlier.

Points and miles

An entire universe I have stayed away from. The idea: collect frequent flyer points through credit-card spending and flight loyalty, redeem for business-class flights that would cost \$5,000+ in cash for the equivalent of \$200 in fees. The math works, but only if you fly the same route patterns often enough to concentrate loyalty in one alliance.

The three big alliances: **Star Alliance** (United, Lufthansa, Singapore, ANA, Thai), **Oneworld** (American, British Airways, Qantas, Cathay, JAL), **SkyTeam** (Delta, Air France, KLM, Korean). Pick one alliance, fly its members, accumulate. If you want to go deeper: The Points Guy and Frequent Miler are the two best free resources.

Layovers as stopovers

Some airlines let you book a long layover in their hub city as a free stopover (Singapore Airlines with Singapore, Icelandair with Reykjavik, Qatar with Doha, Turkish with Istanbul). Two trips for the price of one if you plan it. Search "stopover programme" plus the airline name. I personally prefer non-stop, but if you are doing this route only once in your life, the stopover is often worth the extra day.

TIMING

When to *book*.

THE RULES. ROUTE, DAY, TIME OF YEAR, ALL MATTER.

"How far ahead should I book a flight" is the question travel websites refuse to answer honestly because the answer changes by route. Here is what actually works.

BY ROUTE DISTANCE

Long-haul (Asia ↔ Europe, Asia ↔ Americas, transatlantic)

Book **1 to 2 months ahead**. The sweet spot is roughly 6 to 8 weeks before departure. Earlier than that and prices are still high because airlines have not started discounting; later than that and the cheap fare buckets are sold out. The exception is peak season (December, July, August): for these months, book 3 to 4 months ahead.

Regional within Asia, Europe, or the Americas

Book **2 to 6 weeks ahead** normally. Regional flights have shorter price curves because budget airlines run them. Last-minute deals exist but are rare. For short-haul I check prices weekly and book when something drops, rather than fixing a date months ahead.

Very last minute (under 7 days)

Almost always expensive on long-haul. Sometimes surprisingly cheap on short-haul in Asia or low-cost Europe if a flight is undersold. Worth checking, never worth relying on.

BY DAY OF WEEK AND TIME OF DAY

The old "Tuesday at 3am is cheapest" advice is largely dead. Airline pricing is dynamic now. What still holds:

TIMING · WHAT STILL WORKS

- Tuesday, Wednesday, and Saturday *departure dates* are usually cheaper than Friday or Sunday departures.
- The day you *book on* matters far less than the day you *fly on*. Book whenever the price drops; do not wait for "Tuesday at 3am."
- Early morning and late-night flights are cheaper than midday flights. Pay this premium only if your sleep matters.
- One-stop flights are typically 20-40% cheaper than non-stop on long-haul. Decide what your time is worth.
- Shoulder season (the month either side of peak) is usually 30-50% cheaper than peak for the same route.

PRICE BANDS

What flights *actually* cost.

REALISTIC RANGES. ROUND TRIP. SHOULDER SEASON PRICING.

If you have never flown a particular route, you have no reference point for what is cheap and what is overpriced. These bands give you that reference. Numbers are round-trip, in USD, for a single adult, booking 6-8 weeks ahead, flying in shoulder season. Peak season (Christmas, July-August, Lunar New Year) adds 30-60%. Last-minute adds another 30-50%.

INTRA-ASIA AND SHORT-HAUL

Within <i>Southeast Asia</i>	Economy \$80–250 · Business \$300–700
SE Asia ↔ <i>Japan / Korea</i>	Economy \$300–600 · Business \$1,200–2,500
SE Asia ↔ <i>India / Middle East</i>	Economy \$250–500 · Business \$1,000–2,000
Within <i>Europe</i>	Economy \$50–250 · Business \$300–800
Within <i>North America</i>	Economy \$150–400 · Business \$600–1,500

LONG-HAUL, BETWEEN REGIONS

<i>SE Asia ↔ Europe</i>	Economy \$600–1,200 · Business \$2,500–5,500
<i>SE Asia ↔ North America</i>	Economy \$900–1,800 · Business \$3,500–7,500
<i>Europe ↔ North America</i>	Economy \$400–900 · Business \$2,000–5,000
<i>Europe ↔ Middle East</i>	Economy \$300–700 · Business \$1,500–3,500
<i>Europe ↔ South America</i>	Economy \$700–1,400 · Business \$2,500–5,500
<i>North America ↔ South America</i>	Economy \$400–900 · Business \$1,800–4,000
<i>Asia ↔ Australia / NZ</i>	Economy \$500–1,000 · Business \$2,000–4,500

If a quoted price is significantly above the top of these bands, it is overpriced for that route in normal conditions. Either you are looking at peak season, you are booking too late, or you are searching the wrong website. Run the stack again.

THE BUSINESS QUESTION

When to *fly up front*.

10+ HOURS. THE RULE I LIVE BY.

Business class is the single biggest spending decision in long-haul travel. Done right, it is the difference between landing fresh and landing destroyed. Done wrong, it is \$3,000 spent on a meal and a wider seat for a six-hour flight where economy was fine.

MY RULE

On flights of **10 hours or more**, I fly business if budget allows. Below 10 hours, economy is fine. The reason is straightforward: under 10 hours you arrive functional regardless of cabin. Over 10 hours, the difference between sleeping flat and sleeping upright determines whether your first day of the trip is usable or a write-off.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY LOOK FOR

BUSINESS · WORTH PAYING FOR

- *Lie-flat seat*. Non-negotiable. Some "business class" on short-haul European routes is just an economy seat with the middle blocked. Check the aircraft seat map before booking.
- *Direct aisle access*. 1-2-1 seat configuration is best. 2-2-2 means climbing over a stranger.
- *Lounge access at the connection*. Often the difference-maker on a long itinerary.
- *The airline matters*. Singapore, Qatar, ANA, Emirates business is genuinely premium. Some legacy US carriers' business class is borderline embarrassing for the price.

HOW I ACTUALLY BOOK IT

Direct with the airline, or through Booking.com with the Genius discount applied. Never through an unknown OTA at this price point. If something goes wrong, you need the airline talking to you directly, not an offshore call centre for a discount site reading from a script.

Watch airline sales. Major carriers run business-class sales 2 to 4 times a year, particularly Singapore Airlines, Qatar, Etihad, and Cathay. A typical \$5,000 business fare drops to \$2,500 during these sales. Sign up to the airline newsletter even if you do not normally read airline emails; the sales come through this channel.

MY TAKE

*Business class is not a flex. It is a **recovery tool**. If you are flying 14 hours to start a 7-day trip, paying 3x for the flight to save 2 days of jet lag on either end is mathematically obvious. If you are flying 14 hours for a 14-day trip, economy is fine. Decide based on the trip, not the destination.*

LOGISTICS · PART TWO

Packing.

CARRY-ON FIRST. CHECK THE REST. NEVER THE OTHER WAY AROUND.

After twenty-two-plus countries, my packing philosophy is simple. Everything that matters goes in the carry-on. Everything else goes in the checked bag, and if the checked bag never arrives, the trip still works. People who put their critical items in checked luggage have not lost a bag yet. They will.

THE CARRY-ON RULE

If your carry-on is lost, you should be able to land, get to the hotel, sleep, shower, and start your trip. Anything you need to make that happen lives in the carry-on. Everything else is optional and can go below.

CARRY-ON ESSENTIAL 01

Headphones

Noise-cancelling, over-ear if budget allows

The single most important travel item. The difference between a brutal long-haul flight and a tolerable one. Bose, Sony, AirPods Max all work. Even cheap noise-cancellers are better than nothing on the plane. Charge them before departure.

CARRY-ON ESSENTIAL 02

Toiletries

Full kit, not just toothbrush

If your checked bag is lost on a Friday night flight to Bali, every shop is closed and you have nothing for two days. Pack the full kit in the carry-on: toothbrush, paste, deodorant, sunscreen, anything you actually use. Hotel toiletries do not replace your own.

CARRY-ON ESSENTIAL 03

Spare clothes

One full change minimum

Underwear, socks, a t-shirt, light pants or shorts. Enough to function for one day if the checked bag is delayed 24 hours. People who skip this step always regret it.

CARRY-ON ESSENTIAL 04

Power banks

Two at minimum, one always charged

Your phone is your map, your tickets, your translator, your money. Flat phone in a new country is a real problem. Carry two power banks, keep one fully charged at all times. Airline regulations require power banks in carry-on, not checked, so this is also a legal requirement.

THE FULL CARRY-ON CHECKLIST

ALWAYS IN THE CARRY-ON

- ☐ Passport, with at least 6 months validity from your travel date
- ☐ Wallet, with at least two cards (one Visa, one Mastercard) on separate networks
- ☐ Phone, fully charged at departure
- ☐ Headphones (see above)
- ☐ Power banks, at least one fully charged
- ☐ Charging cables for everything you carry. Universal adapter if going to a new region.
- ☐ Laptop or tablet if you work, in a sleeve
- ☐ Toiletries, a complete travel-size kit
- ☐ One full change of clothes
- ☐ Any medication you take, with original prescriptions if needed for customs
- ☐ Empty water bottle, refilled after security
- ☐ Eye mask and earplugs if flying long-haul
- ☐ A printout or screenshot of your hotel booking and onward ticket (some countries demand proof of onward travel at immigration)

BY TRIP TYPE

TROPICAL (BALI, THAILAND, CARIBBEAN)

- + Light fabrics, linen, cotton. Skip the synthetic gym wear.
- + Reef-safe sunscreen (mineral, zinc-based). Several countries enforce this now.
- + Sandals plus one pair of sneakers
- + One layer for over-air-conditioned restaurants and flights
- + Bug spray. DEET works. Citronella is theatre.
- + Quick-dry travel towel for beach hotels with no beach towels
- + Modest clothing for temples and religious sites

COLD (REYKJAVIK, WINTER EUROPE, HELSINKI, TOKYO JAN-FEB)

- + Real winter jacket. Down or synthetic-fill, water-resistant outer.
- + Thermal base layer. Merino wool is the right answer.
- + Waterproof boots, broken in
- + Gloves, hat, scarf. Lose any of these and the trip suffers.
- + Hand and toe warmers (the disposable kind)
- + Sunglasses for snow glare (often forgotten in winter)
- + Moisturiser and lip balm. Cold air destroys skin.

CITY (LONDON, TOKYO, NYC)

- + Walking shoes you have already broken in. New shoes will destroy your trip.
- + One nicer outfit for dinners and bars
- + Layers. Most cities have unpredictable weather even in shoulder season.
- + A small daypack for the days you actually walk the city
- + Light scarf or pashmina (works for cold restaurants, planes, modest sites)
- + Compact umbrella in autumn or spring
- + Reading material for cafe afternoons

ACTIVE OR ADVENTURE (HIKING, SURF, DIVE)

- + Specific gear stays in the checked bag (boots, fins, board shorts)
- + Activity-specific clothing for the first day, in carry-on as backup
- + Quick-dry everything. Cotton stays wet for hours.
- + Rash guard or UPF top for sun protection
- + Lightweight rain jacket regardless of season
- + First-aid kit basics: blister plasters, antihistamine, pain relief
- + Dry bag for electronics on boats or in rain

MY TAKE

Pack what you need for tomorrow, not what you might use in two weeks. Most over-packers carry "just in case" items they never touch. Buy what you forgot at the destination. Everywhere in this guide has shops. The only things you cannot easily replace are passport, prescriptions, electronics, and trust in your luggage.

LOGISTICS · PART THREE

Money.

CARDS, CASH, FEES. HOW TO NOT GET DESTROYED BY EXCHANGE RATES AND ATM CHARGES.

The wrong setup costs you 5-10% of everything you spend abroad in invisible fees. The right setup costs you almost nothing. The difference comes down to which card you swipe, where you withdraw cash, and whether you let the terminal "do the conversion for you" (you should not).

THE CARD STACK

PRIMARY SPENDING CARD

A multi-currency travel card

Wise, Revolut, or your local equivalent

These let you hold and spend in 30-40 currencies at the real interbank exchange rate, with no foreign-transaction fees. The single biggest money upgrade for anyone who travels. Order the physical card 2 weeks before you leave. Top up the wallet from your bank.

BACKUP CARD

A real credit card

From a different bank, on a different network

If Wise or Revolut freezes your card (it happens, usually on the first ATM withdrawal abroad), you need a real backup. Visa or Mastercard from a major bank. Carry it separately from the primary, ideally in the hotel safe when not in use.

CASH CARD

ATM access card with low fees

Wise and Revolut both work for this

For cash withdrawals abroad. Some banks (Charles Schwab in the US, Starling in the UK, Wise globally) refund all ATM fees. Use only ATMs attached to actual banks, not the freestanding ones in convenience stores or airports.

THE FIVE RULES

MONEY · FIVE RULES

- Always pay in local currency. When the terminal asks "do you want to be charged in your home currency?" the answer is always no. Their conversion rate is 3-7% worse than your card's.
- Use bank ATMs only. Freestanding ATMs in tourist zones charge \$5-10 per withdrawal and offer worse rates. Inside an actual bank, the fee is usually under \$3.
- Withdraw bigger amounts less often. ATM fees are per transaction, not per dollar. One \$400 withdrawal beats four \$100s.
- Tell your bank you are travelling through their app, or your real card will freeze the first time you use it abroad.
- Carry small cash in two places. Some in your wallet, some in your bag or hotel safe. Never all in one spot.

HOW MUCH CASH TO CARRY

Depends entirely on where you are. The rough rule: enough for two days of expenses in places where cards work everywhere (Europe, Japan, Singapore, North America). Enough for a week in places where cash is king (rural Asia, parts of Latin America, North African medinas, small Greek islands, all temples and markets). Get a small amount at the airport ATM on arrival to handle taxi and tip. Top up at a bank ATM in town the next day at a better rate.

MY TAKE

*If you only do **one** thing from this section: get a Wise or Revolut card before your next international trip. The savings over a single 10-day trip pay for the card three times over. Everything else is optimisation.*

LOGISTICS · PART FOUR

Travel day.

THE ROUTINE. SAME EVERY FLIGHT. NO THINKING REQUIRED.

Travel days are mostly logistics, broken into predictable phases. The people who travel well treat each phase the same way every time and stop making decisions on the day. The people who suffer treat every flight as a one-off and reinvent the routine every trip.

24 HOURS BEFORE

Check in online when the airline window opens (24 hours before for most carriers). Get seat selection done while there are still good seats. Aisle on long-haul if you drink water properly. Window if you want to sleep.

Charge everything overnight. Phone, headphones, power banks, laptop, watch. Check the carry-on packing checklist (above). Confirm the airport transfer the night before.

THE AIRPORT PHASE

AIRPORT · THE ROUTINE

- Arrive 3 hours before international, 90 minutes before domestic. Less is asking for trouble.
- Liquid bag and laptop come out of the carry-on before security, in a separate tray.
- After security, refill the water bottle.
- Find the gate first, then food. Knowing where the gate is removes 90% of airport stress.
- Sit near the gate from boarding minus 30. Boarding is usually quicker than the announcement suggests.

THE FLIGHT ITSELF

Short-haul (under 6 hours)

Hydrate. Eat lightly. Walk the aisle once an hour. Land functional.

Medium-haul (6-10 hours)

Same as above plus a meal at your destination's local meal time, even if it does not line up with the cabin service. Adjust your watch to destination time as soon as you board.

Long-haul (10+ hours)

Light eating only. Plane food is not great for the stomach and the cabin pressure makes digestion sluggish. Eat about half of what the cabin serves. Drink water aggressively (two litres minimum for a 12-hour flight). Avoid alcohol; the dehydration compounds the jet lag. For sleep, a melatonin or doctor-prescribed sleep aid is fair game on the longest flights. Compression socks, eye mask, neck pillow if you have one. Move every 90 minutes minimum.

ON ARRIVAL · THE RECOVERY ROUTINE

ARRIVAL · RECOVERY ROUTINE

- Cold shower. Resets the nervous system, kills the brain fog from a long flight.
- Real food. Something fresh, local, savoury. Not airline food. Not a hotel sandwich.
- Get outside. Daylight resets the circadian rhythm faster than anything else. 30 minutes minimum.
- Resist the nap. If you arrive in the morning, push through to evening. A 20-minute nap is fine, anything longer ruins the first night's sleep.
- Sleep at local time, not when you feel tired. One night of forced reset is better than three nights of trying to recover.

MY TAKE

*Jet lag is mostly **dehydration plus circadian confusion**. Hydration on the plane, daylight on arrival, a cold shower, a real meal, and sleeping at local time. Five things. They are not exotic. They work better than any supplement.*

LOGISTICS · PART FIVE

SIM & eSIM.

DATA ON ARRIVAL. SORTED BEFORE YOU LEAVE THE AIRPORT.

Getting internet on day one is non-negotiable. Without it you cannot Uber, you cannot read a map, you cannot translate a menu, you cannot message your hotel. The wrong way to handle this is to use your home plan's roaming and pay \$15 a day. The right way takes 10 minutes before departure and costs \$5-15 per trip.

THREE OPTIONS

OPTION 01 · BEST FOR MOST PEOPLE

eSIM

Airalo, Holafly, Nomad, Saily

Download an eSIM app, buy a data plan for your destination, install before you fly. The eSIM activates the moment you land and connect to a tower. No queuing at the airport, no swapping physical SIMs, no losing your home number. Works on most phones from 2018 onwards (iPhone XS+, most Samsung/Google flagships). Airalo is the most popular; Holafly offers unlimited data plans in many countries; all the major ones work.

OPTION 02 · BEST FOR LONG TRIPS

Local physical SIM

Buy at the airport or a phone shop in town

Cheaper per gigabyte than eSIM if you are staying 2+ weeks in one country. The trade-off: you lose access to your home number for the trip, and the SIM has to fit your phone. Buy at the official carrier's airport booth (not the kiosk in the arrivals hall, which marks them up 2-3x). Bring your passport; many countries require ID registration.

OPTION 03 · FOR SHORT TRIPS WITH NO SETUP

International roaming on your home plan

Only if your plan includes it free or cheap

Some plans (Google Fi, T-Mobile Magenta, EE Roam Like Home) include international data at no extra cost or a fixed daily fee. If that is your situation, just use it for a short trip. Otherwise, pay-per-day roaming at \$10-15 per day is highway robbery for 7+ day trips.

THE RULE

DATA · THE RULE

- *Under 3 days* in a country: eSIM is fastest and best.
- *3 days to 2 weeks*: eSIM still wins on convenience. Cost difference is small.
- *2+ weeks in one country*: local physical SIM is cheaper.
- *Multi-country trip*: regional eSIM (Airalo's "Eurolink", "Asialink" or similar) covers multiple countries on one plan.

LOGISTICS · PART SIX

Travel *insurance*.

BORING UNTIL IT MATTERS. THEN THE ONLY THING THAT MATTERS.

Most travel insurance posts are written by insurance affiliates and are useless. Here is the actual question to ask: if I broke my leg or got food poisoning bad enough for a hospital, what happens? In most of the countries in this book, paying out of pocket for a serious medical issue costs more than the trip itself. Insurance is not optional.

WHAT YOU ACTUALLY NEED

COVERAGE 01 · NON-NEGOTIABLE

Medical and emergency evacuation

\$100,000+ medical, \$500,000+ evacuation

The big one. Hospital care abroad without insurance can run \$10,000+ for a few nights. Emergency air evacuation from a remote location (Bali to Singapore, Tulum to Miami) costs \$50,000-100,000+. This is the only category that genuinely cannot be self-funded for most people. Get this no matter what.

COVERAGE 02 · USEFUL

Trip cancellation and trip interruption

Covers refund of non-refundable bookings if you cannot travel

Worth it for expensive trips (over \$3,000 in bookings) or trips around weather-sensitive months (hurricane season, peak winter). Skip for short, cheap trips.

COVERAGE 03 · NICE TO HAVE

Baggage and electronics

Lost or stolen luggage, phones, laptops

Usually capped low (\$1,000-2,000 max) and full of exclusions. Worth having but do not pay extra for it. Already covered by most credit cards that have travel benefits.

WHERE TO BUY IT

The main names: **SafetyWing** (popular with digital nomads, subscription model, easy to extend), **World Nomads** (good for adventurous activities like diving, hiking, skiing), **Allianz Travel** (traditional, comprehensive, slightly more expensive), **Heymondo** (Europe-focused, well-priced).

If you have a premium credit card (Chase Sapphire Reserve, Amex Platinum, equivalent), check the travel insurance included with it before paying for a separate policy. Often the coverage is enough for most short trips.

INSURANCE · THREE RULES

- *Buy before you leave.* Most policies require purchase before departure. You cannot insure backwards.
- *Read the activity exclusions.* Motorbikes, diving below 30m, "extreme sports" are often excluded. Add coverage if needed.
- *Save the policy number to your phone* and email it to a trusted contact at home. If you need it, you need it fast.

LOGISTICS · PART SEVEN

Scam *awareness.*

PATTERNS, NOT PARANOIA. KNOW THE MOVES. THE TRIP STAYS FINE.

The risk of being scammed abroad is real but small. The risk of being scared into a worse trip by overreacting to it is bigger. The right mindset: know the common patterns, recognise them when they start, walk away. Most scams need your cooperation. Remove that, and they fail.

THE FIVE PATTERNS THAT COVER MOST SCAMS

PATTERN 01

"The friendly stranger"

Local approaches you, perfect English, asks where you are from

Then offers to "show you somewhere nearby" or invites you to "their cousin's bar." You will be charged 10x for drinks, or pressured into buying something. Real locals rarely approach tourists unprompted in tourist zones. Smile, decline, walk on.

PATTERN 02

"It is closed today, but I can show you another"

Outside temples, museums, monuments

Someone tells you the attraction is closed for a holiday, ceremony, or renovation, and offers to take you to a "better one" (with kickbacks attached). Verify closures only at the actual entrance, not from people in the street.

PATTERN 03

"The unmetered taxi"

Driver offers a flat rate before turning on the meter

Always 3-5x the metered fare. Demand the meter. If they refuse, get out and find another. Better: use the app the locals use (Grab in SE Asia, Bolt in Europe, Uber in the Americas, Didi in China).

PATTERN 04

"The card cloned at the ATM"*Skimming devices on freestanding ATMs*

Especially common in tourist zones. Cover the keypad when entering your PIN. Use ATMs inside actual bank branches. Notice if anything on the card slot looks odd. Notify your bank immediately if charges appear you did not make.

PATTERN 05

"The pickpocket distraction"*Someone bumps you, spills something on you, or shows you a paper to read*

While their accomplice lifts your phone or wallet. Common in Paris metro, Barcelona Las Ramblas, Rome trains, Naples streets. Keep wallet in front pocket, phone in a zipped bag, bag across your body. The distraction is the tell; if something feels staged, it is.

THE MINDSET

SCAMS · THE MINDSET

- *If a stranger creates urgency, it is a scam.* Real interactions do not have a clock.
- *If a price is not on a menu, it does not exist.* Always ask the price before ordering anything not listed.
- *If you feel pressured, leave.* Politeness is not worth what it might cost you.
- *Trust the local app over the local pitch.* The booking, the taxi, the menu, the map.
- *Most people are not scammers.* A healthy 95% of strangers in any of these places are fine. Awareness, not paranoia.

LOGISTICS · PART EIGHT

Apps to *download*.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE. THE PHONE IS THE TRIP.

A traveller's phone is their map, ticket, translator, taxi, wallet, and lifeline. The apps below are what I actually have on my phone. Download them at home on wifi, sign in, save anything that needs offline access. Doing this on hotel wifi in a new country wastes the first morning.

THE ESSENTIALS

MAPS

Google Maps + *Maps.me*

Always. Download offline maps before you fly.

Google Maps for general use; Maps.me for offline-first navigation when you have no data. Both let you save the entire city or country as an offline map. Do this at home, on home wifi, before every trip.

TRANSLATION

Google Translate

Download the language pack for offline use

Camera translation works on menus and signs even without internet, if you have downloaded the offline language pack. The single most useful piece of software for non-English-speaking destinations.

RIDE-HAILING

Grab · Bolt · Uber · Didi · Cabify

Download the right one for the region before you land

Grab (Southeast Asia), Bolt (Europe and Africa), Uber (Americas, parts of Europe and ME), Didi (China), Cabify (Spain and Latin America). Local ride apps remove the taxi-scam problem entirely and are usually cheaper.

HOTELS AND STAYS

Booking.com + Agoda

Booking for everywhere; Agoda for Asia specifically

Booking.com works globally and has the loyalty (Genius) programme. Agoda often has lower prices on Asian hotels because of regional pricing deals. Cross-check both for any stay in Asia.

FLIGHTS

Google Flights · Skyscanner · Trip.com · airline apps

See the Flights section above

In addition, install the app of whichever airline you booked. Check-in, boarding passes, gate-change alerts, baggage tracking all live in the airline app.

DATA AND ESIM

Airalo (or your eSIM provider)

Install and buy the plan before you fly

eSIM apps work best when set up on home wifi. Top up data in-app while travelling if needed.

CURRENCY

XE Currency or Wise

Quick lookups, no math

XE for a clean read-only converter; Wise if you are using their card and want to track real-time rates. Both work offline once initialised.

MONEY

Wise · Revolut · your real bank

See the Money section above

Set up both Wise and Revolut at home, even if you only use one. Two-factor authentication can be a problem when activating these apps abroad, so do all setup before you fly.

USEFUL, NOT ESSENTIAL

Some others I would recommend: **Rome2Rio** (works out how to get from A to B by every transport mode), **Citymapper** (best public-transit navigation in major cities), **Splitwise** (group travel cost-splitting), **TripIt** (auto-organises all bookings into one itinerary by reading your email), **HappyCow** (best vegan and vegetarian restaurant finder anywhere), **SeatGuru** (which seats on which planes are best), and **What3words** (precise location-sharing in places without addresses).

MY TAKE

Download everything at home, on home wifi, before you fly. Two-factor authentication is the single most common reason people land in a new country with no working bank app, no booking confirmations, and no way to call a taxi. Do the setup before you board, not after.

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